

HOMER

THE ODYSSEY

Complete provisional interior architecture proof

7 x 10 inch hardcover / 80# coated paper target

Translation status: first-pass draft; Greek-fidelity and editorial gates remain open.

BOOK 1

First-pass working translation

Tell me of the man of many turnings, Muse,
who wandered far, after he had brought down Troy's
sacred citadel; who saw the cities of many men
and learned their minds, and suffered many griefs
upon the sea within his heart, striving to save
his life and bring his companions home. Yet still
he could not save them, though he longed to do so:
their own blind folly brought them to destruction,
for they devoured the cattle of the Sun,
and he took from them the day of their returning.
Begin wherever you will, goddess born of Zeus;
give us this story also. All the others now,
who had escaped the steep destruction of the war,
were home, beyond the battle and the sea. He alone,
still longing for his wife and for the day of return,
was held in hollow caves by the lady nymph,
Calypso, shining among the deathless ones.
But when the circling years had brought the hour
the gods had spun for him to reach his home,
to Ithaca, nor even there escape from toil
among his friends, the gods took pity on him all,
save Poseidon; he, unrelenting, nursed his wrath
against godlike Odysseus, till he touched
the land he loved.
But Poseidon had gone to the distant Ethiopians,
to share their hecatomb, at the earth's far edge;
there the gods were gathered, and he among them.
The father of gods and men began to speak,
remembering Aegisthus, whom famed Orestes killed.
“Look how mortals blame the gods,” he said, “and say
their evils come from us. Yet they themselves, by folly,
make sorrow beyond what fate has given them.
So Aegisthus, against fate, took Agamemnon's wife
and murdered him when he came home from Troy.

He knew the god's warning, for Hermes had told him:
do not kill the king, do not pursue his wife;
the son of Atreus will be avenged by Orestes,
when he comes to manhood and longs for his country.
But Aegisthus would not listen. Now he has paid
for all of it at once.”

Then the grey-eyed Athena answered him:
“Father Zeus, son of Cronus, highest of rulers,
that man deserved the death that came upon him.
Would that every man who acts as he did might perish!
But my heart is troubled for the wise Odysseus,
who has so long been kept from his friends and home,
on an island in the sea, where the nymph, the daughter
of the sea's old strength, holds him in her hollow caves.
Poseidon still keeps the anger that began with the Cyclops,
whom Odysseus blinded, the most powerful of his sons.
Zeus, cloud-gatherer, answered: “If your heart is set,
go now and ask the swift one, Hermes, to tell the nymph
that we have decided: let the steadfast man go home.
He will not die before he sees his friends again.”
Athena said: “Father, if this is truly your will,
send Hermes at once. I will go to Ithaca myself,
and strengthen the heart of his son, so that he calls
the long-haired Achaeans to assembly and speaks
against the suitors who consume his house and wealth.
Then I will lead him to Pylos and to Lacedaemon,
to seek news of his father, if perhaps that report
may lift him into manhood and give him a name.”
She fastened beneath her feet the golden sandals,
deathless, winged, that carry her above the water
and over the measureless earth, swift as the wind.
She took the spear, great, heavy, edged with bronze,
with which the daughter of a mighty father breaks
the ranks of heroes when her anger is awakened.
Down from Olympus she came. She stood in Ithaca,
before the doors of Odysseus, at the outer court,
holding the shape of Mentès, lord of the Taphians.
There she found the proud suitors. They were amusing

themselves with stones and dice before the doors,
while the servants cut the meat and mixed the wine.
Telemachus saw her first. He sat among the feasters,
grieving within his heart, imagining his noble father,
if he might come and scatter these men from the house,
recover his honor, and rule his own possessions.
He went directly to the gate, since it shamed him
to let a stranger stand waiting. He took her hand,
received her spear, and spoke with winged words:
“Stranger, welcome. You shall be received among us.
First take food, and afterward tell us what you seek.”
He led her through the house, and set the spear
against a shining pillar in the spear-stand,
where many other weapons rested, long ago
carried by Odysseus, but now covered from sight.
He brought her to a chair, carved and polished,
beautiful, high-backed, with a woven cloth laid over it;
for himself he drew a smaller seat beside her,
apart from the suitors, lest the stranger be disturbed
by their loud shouting and their insolent feast,
and lest, while eating, he should question him
about his father, whom he had so long desired.
A maid brought water in a golden pitcher,
and poured it over their hands into a silver basin.
Then an honored housekeeper set a polished table
before them. She brought bread, and many dishes,
giving freely from the stores she kept within.
The carver lifted platters of many kinds of meat,
and set beside them cups of gold. The herald
came often, pouring wine among the guests.
The suitors entered then, the proud young men,
and sat in order on the benches and the chairs.
The heralds poured water over their hands;
the serving women filled baskets with bread;
and boys crowned the mixing bowls with wine.
They reached for the food placed before them.
When they had eaten and had driven hunger away,
the singer Phemius took his resonant lyre;

the suitors had compelled him to sing among them.
He struck the opening chord, and began a song
of the hard return of the Achaeans from Troy,
the homeward passage the gods had made bitter.
From her upper room Penelope heard the inspired singer,
and came down the polished stairs—not alone:
two attendants followed close behind her.
When she had drawn near the suitors, she stood
beside the pillar supporting the roof, and held
a shining veil before her face. Then she spoke
through tears to the divine singer:
“Phemius, many other songs you know to delight
the hearts of mortal men, the deeds of gods and heroes,
which singers make famous. Choose one of these,
and let them drink in silence. But do not sing
this sorrowful return. It cuts my heart within me,
for I remember the man I cannot cease to mourn.
His fame was wide through Hellas and midmost Argos.”
Then wise Telemachus answered her:
“Mother, why deny the singer that he wishes?
The singers are not to blame for what has come;
Zeus gives to each man as he himself determines.
He sings the hardest fate of the Danaans.
Let him go on, since men most praise the newest song.
Your heart and spirit should endure it, too:
Odysseus was not the only man to lose the day
of his return from Troy. Many others perished.
Go to your chamber now, and care for what belongs to you:
the loom, the distaff, and the work you give your women.
Speech is the concern of every man, but mine above all;
in this house I hold the power.”
She was astonished, and returned into the house,
keeping her son's wise saying in her heart.
When she had reached her upper room with her attendants,
she wept for Odysseus, her dear husband, until bright-eyed Athena
cast sweet sleep upon her eyelids.
The suitors stirred the shadowed hall with noise,
each one desiring to lie beside her.

Telemachus then addressed them. His voice was steady:
“You suitors of my mother, who carry yourselves with pride,
let us feast in quiet, and take pleasure in listening.
It is a beautiful thing to hear a singer such as this.
At dawn let us go to the assembly, every man,
so I may speak openly and order you away.
Leave this house. Hold your own banquets elsewhere,
and consume your own possessions, taking turns by house.
But if you think it better and more profitable
to consume one man's goods without payment,
then waste them. I will cry to the everlasting gods,
and may Zeus make the debt come due.”

They all fell silent, and looked at him in wonder.
Antinous, son of Eupeithes, answered him:
“Telemachus, surely the gods themselves have taught you
to speak so boldly, and to make your words a law.
May the son of Cronus never grant you kingship
in sea-girt Ithaca, though it is your inheritance.”

Telemachus answered him: “Antinous, if the god wills it,
I would accept that gift. Kingship is no shame.
But if there is another better man in Ithaca,
let him rule; I ask no more than my father's house
and the people who were once his to command.”

Eurymachus, son of Polybus, replied:
“The gods alone know who will rule in Ithaca.
But your possessions remain your own; no one will take them,
while the island stands and the blood in you remains.
Tell us, stranger, from what country have you come?
What city is yours? What family claims you?
You have not arrived on foot; you must have crossed the sea.
Did you come as a trader, or as one who roams the waves,
like pirates who risk their lives upon the deep,
and bring danger to other men?”

Telemachus answered: “Stranger, since you ask me plainly,
I will tell you. Mentos is my name; I am the son
of wise Anchialus, and I rule the oar-loving Taphians.
I have come here in my ship and with my companions,
crossing the dark sea toward men who speak another tongue.

I carry bright iron to Temesa, and my companions carry bronze.
I have moored my ship beyond the city, at Reithron's harbor,
beneath the wooded hill. We claim an ancient friendship,
inherited from our fathers, as old Laertes will confirm.
Go ask him, they say, though he no longer enters the town,
but stays in the country, grieving, with one old woman
who prepares his meals and washes the dirt from his body
when age and weariness have taken him.”

Telemachus answered him, speaking quietly:

“I will not trouble the old man. He has suffered much.
My father left no brother or son behind to take his place.
He is gone, and no one knows where the earth has hidden him.
He may be alive upon the mainland, or on the sea,
or dead beneath it. My mother’s family and the island’s people
press me, and these men consume my house.”

Athena, in the likeness of Mentès, answered him:

“It is not fitting for you to remain a child forever.
You have heard what kind of man your father was,
and how he returned from Troy with honor.
Think how Orestes won renown among all men
when he avenged his father and killed Aegisthus,
the treacherous man who murdered Agamemnon.
You too, my friend, must show your strength and courage,
so those who come after you will praise your name.
As for me, I will return to my ship and my companions.
Tomorrow call the people to assembly and speak before them all.
Order the suitors to leave. Then go to Pylos and Sparta,
and ask about your father, whether any mortal has seen him,
or whether report from Zeus has reached the cities.
If you hear that he lives and is coming home,
endure your grief for one more year, though it cuts you.
But if you learn that he is dead and gone,
return to your homeland, build a mound, and honor him
with all the funeral rites that the dead are owed.
Then give your mother to another husband, if she wishes,
and devise a death for those men who consume your wealth.
You are no longer a child. Have you not heard
how Orestes became famous throughout the world?

Go now, and let your strength be seen.
 Your father and your uncle will have something to say
 about your name, if you are truly their son.”

Telemachus answered: “All this, stranger, you have spoken
 with kindness, as a father speaks to his son.
 I will not forget it. Stay, though you are eager to leave,
 and bathe; accept a gift, and return to your ship
 with joy, carrying a precious thing from me,
 such as hosts give to a guest whom they honor.”

Athena, with flashing eyes, answered him:
 “Do not hold me here, since I am already eager to go.
 Give the gift when I return, and I will take it home.
 Choose something beautiful. You will receive as much in return.”

So she vanished like a bird, and was gone.
 Telemachus knew then, in his heart, that a god had spoken.
 He went among the suitors, no longer walking with lowered eyes.
 The renowned singer still sang, while all listened silently.
 Telemachus addressed them, and his voice carried:
 “You suitors of my mother, who bear yourselves with pride,
 let us feast in silence, and take pleasure in the song.
 At dawn we will go to the assembly, every man,
 so I may tell you plainly to leave this house.
 Hold your own feasts elsewhere, and consume your own possessions,
 going from house to house by turns. But if you decide
 that it is more profitable to consume one man's wealth
 without paying, then waste it. I will cry to the gods,
 and may Zeus make the debt come due.”

They fell silent and looked at him in wonder.
 Antinous, son of Eupeithes, spoke among them:
 “The gods themselves must have taught you to speak so boldly,
 and made your words stand like a king's. May Zeus never grant you
 the kingship in sea-girt Ithaca, though it belongs by birth to you.”

Telemachus answered: “Antinous, if the god should give it,
 I would accept the gift. Kingship is no shame.
 But if another man is better, let him rule the island.
 I ask only to be lord of my own house and possessions,
 the house that Odysseus won, and which no one may consume.”

Eurymachus, son of wise Polybus, replied:

“The gods alone know who will rule in Ithaca.
But tell us, stranger, from what country you come?
What city claims you? Who are your parents?
You have not come on foot. Surely you crossed the sea.
Are you a trader, or a wanderer like the pirates
who risk their lives and bring danger to other men?”
Telemachus answered: “Since you ask me plainly, I will tell you.
Mentes is my name, son of wise Anchialus, and I rule the Taphians,
who love the oar. I have come with my ship and companions,
crossing the dark sea toward men of another tongue.
I carry bright iron to Temesa, and my companions carry bronze.
My ship lies beyond the city, at Reithron's harbor,
beneath the wooded hill. Our fathers were friends,
as old Laertes will tell you, though grief keeps him in the country.
But now our guest has departed, and night has come upon us.
I must prepare the ship and call the people to assembly.”
The suitors rose and went to their houses.
Telemachus followed the torch held by the faithful old nurse Eurynome,
who had carried him in her arms when he was newly born.
She opened the door, and he lay down, turning over in his mind
the journey Athena had set before him.
Throughout the night he could not sleep.

Source range: Book 1. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 2

First-pass working translation

When dawn appeared, the early-born and rosy-fingered,
Telemachus rose from bed and dressed himself.
He tied his sharp sword over his shoulder,
bound bright sandals beneath his shining feet,
and went out from his room, looking like a god.
At once he called the clear-voiced heralds:
“Call the long-haired Achaeans to assembly.”
They called, and the people gathered swiftly.
When they had assembled, Telemachus went among them,
holding the polished scepter, not alone:
two hounds walked beside him, and Athena poured grace
around him, so that all the people looked and wondered.
He sat in his father's seat, and the elders made a place.
Then the hero Aegyptius rose, bent by old age.
He knew the counsels of the past, and spoke among them:
“Hear me, Ithacans. No assembly has met here since the day
when lord Odysseus sailed with the dark ships.
Who called us now? Who has so urgent a need?
Is it a young man, or an older citizen who has heard
some report from the army? Let him speak.
May Zeus make his purpose profitable for us.”
Telemachus was glad to hear this opening.
He stood in the center, and spoke before the people:
“Old man, it is I who called you. Grief has entered me.
I have heard no word of an army, nor any report
that has reached the island. I call you for my private sorrow,
and for the ruin of my house, which touches every man.
My father is lost. He was once your king,
gentle as a father, and you all remember him.
Now the best men of the island, and of the neighboring lands,
consume my house against my will. They court my mother,
and she does not refuse them, nor bring the matter to an end.
They eat the livelihood of my house, and waste it.
As vultures tear a fallen stag, so they tear the house.

I cannot drive them out. I have no strength for that.
This is a shame that will reach all the earth.
Be ashamed for me, and fear the anger of the gods.
If you have any pity, let these men leave my house.
If you yourselves were consumed in this manner,
you would call on the neighbors and the gods.
But if you are shameless, and do not care,
I will call on Zeus, who sees what men do,
and pray that you perish here, without vengeance.”
He threw the scepter to the ground, and wept.
Pity took the whole people. Everyone kept silent.
No one had courage to answer Telemachus.
Only Antinous rose and answered him:
“Telemachus, speaker without restraint, you pour blame on us.
The Achaeans are not responsible. It is your mother,
who knows more tricks than any woman alive.
For three years she has deceived us, and the fourth is beginning.
She promised the best of us: ‘Young men, my suitors,
since noble Odysseus is dead, wait, though you desire marriage,
until I finish this great woven cloth, so that my threads
may not be wasted. It is a shroud for old Laertes,
when the fate that lays men down takes him.
I would be ashamed if he should lie without a winding cloth,
when so many possessions surround him.’
So she spoke, and our proud hearts consented.
By day she wove at the great loom, before us all,
but at night she set torches beside her and unwove it.
She hid the work for three years, and we did not know.
But when the fourth year came, a woman who knew betrayed her,
and we caught her unweaving the shining cloth.
Then she had to finish it, though she did not wish to.
Now answer us plainly, before the people:
send your mother away, and command her to marry
the man her father and her mother choose for her.
If she continues to trouble the sons of the Achaeans,
remember: Athena did not give her the gifts of war,
nor courage in counsel, nor the understanding of kings.
It is a long time since the people of Ithaca had a king

who could rule them. Your mother keeps us waiting,
 and uses this cleverness to build your fortune.”
 Telemachus replied: “Antinous, how could I drive her out,
 against her will, when the gods themselves are her parents?
 If I sent her from the house, my father's anger would pursue me,
 and men would curse me. I will not do that.
 Go on consuming my house if you have no shame.
 But I will ask the gods to make you pay.
 Perhaps Zeus will turn his face toward us,
 and then you will die inside this house, without blood-price.”
 Then two eagles appeared high above the assembly,
 flying close together on the wind. They wheeled and circled,
 and tore each other's necks and cheeks with their talons.
 They fell toward the right, across the crowded town.
 The people saw them, and wondered what the omen meant.
 The elder Halitherses, who knew the flight of birds,
 rose among them and interpreted the sign:
 “Ithacans, hear me. Trouble is close upon these men.
 Odysseus is not far from his land. He is already near,
 bringing death to the suitors, and darkness for them all.
 Let us act before he returns, or before his son becomes strong.”
 Then Mentor, the companion of blameless Odysseus,
 rose and rebuked the people of Ithaca:
 “No longer, Ithacans, does any king hold the scepter;
 you have grown soft, and no one remembers the old rule.
 The suitors are not acting with justice, but with violence.
 May they be few; may their possessions be destroyed.
 Yet I blame the rest of you more: you sit in silence,
 and do not restrain a handful of men.”
 Leocritus answered him, proud and insolent:
 “Mentor, why stir the people against us?
 It is hard for one man, though many are assembled,
 to drive the suitors from the house. Even if Odysseus
 should come himself, the women of Ithaca would not rejoice
 to see him slaughter those who feast there.
 No omen has shown that he will return. Let us depart.
 Telemachus may seek a ship elsewhere, if he wishes;
 we will not provide it, nor carry his message.”

The people went home. Telemachus walked apart,
and prayed to Athena, the one who had assumed the form
of Mentor, companion of his father:

“Hear me, goddess. If you truly came to my house
and spoke as my father’s friend, grant this prayer:
let a ship be made ready, and let twenty companions
go with me over the sea. I will seek news of him,
first at Pylos, then in Lacedaemon beside Menelaus.
If I learn that my father lives and is coming home,
I will endure the suitors for one more year.
But if I hear that he is dead, I will return,
raise a mound for him, and give my mother to a husband.
Then I will make the suitors pay for the years
in which they consumed my house.”

Athena came near him in the shape of Mentor and said:
“You have spoken well. A man who carries such a purpose
must not remain without a ship or without companions.
Go now through the town. Ask for the best vessel,
and gather provisions of wine and water in jars.
I will go among the young men, and call them to you.
There are many ships on Ithaca, old and new.
We will choose the finest, and launch her quickly.”
She went first to the house of Odysseus. There she found
the suitors playing draughts before the doors,
on the hides of oxen they had slaughtered for their feast.
Phemius, the singer, sat apart and sang to them,
because they compelled him. Athena stood before them,
and spoke with the voice and bearing of Mentor:

“Suitors, leave your games. You have feasted long enough.
Let each man go to his own house. I have a message
for Telemachus, who is making ready to sail.”

They stared, and Antinous asked what she meant.
But Athena turned away, and went with Telemachus.
She made him appear so godlike that the people watched,
and the suitors were troubled by the purpose in his face.
Telemachus went to Noemon, son of Phronius,
and asked him quietly for a swift ship:

“Lend me your vessel for two days, with twenty men.

I must cross to Pylos, then to Lacedaemon,
seeking the news of my father. I will return it
with thanks, or pay its worth in your own hands.”
Noemon answered readily: “I will give you the ship.
Come at sunset, and I will make the vessel ready.
She lies by the shore, and I will bring the crew.”
Then Athena, still in Mentor's form, went through the town.
She spoke to the men she trusted, and told them to meet
beside the ship when evening fell. She went also to the house
of Nestor's son, and asked for jars to carry sweet wine.
The housekeeper brought them out, and they filled the jars.
Telemachus went home and stood before the suitors.
His spirit was no longer bowed. He spoke to the herald:
“Medon, draw wine into the jars and set bread aboard.
I go to learn of my father. I will tell the suitors nothing;
they would mock my purpose and make a quarrel of it.”
His nurse Eurycleia heard him, and came weeping:
“Why would you go alone over the sea, dear child?
Your father is far away, and we know nothing of him.
The suitors will plot against you. They are stronger.”
Telemachus answered her: “Do not lament. This voyage
is not without a god. But swear to me that you will tell
my mother nothing for eleven or twelve days,
unless she hears it first from another person.
I would not have her wear herself out with weeping
before I know whether the gods will grant my return.”
Eurycleia swore the oath. She drew wine and water
into the jars, and carried the provisions down to the ship.
Athena meanwhile cast a sweet, deep sleep upon the suitors,
so that their cups fell from their hands and they went home,
each man yawning, and no longer eager for the feast.
Then she took the form of Mentor once more and called:
“The companions are waiting. Do not delay. The wind is fair.”
Telemachus came to the shore. Noemon and his men stood there.
They raised the mast, stretched the dark sail, and drew
the ship into the water. Athena sent a following wind,
fresh from the west, over the loud and shining sea.
They lifted the jars aboard, and brought the black ship

to the deep water. When darkness came, they set the mast,
raised the sail, and poured a libation of wine to the gods.
Athena, bright-eyed, watched from the prow.
So the young prince left the island. The suitors slept,
but in their sleep they dreamed of blood and retribution.
The sea opened before the ship, and the night was full of stars.

Source range: Book 2. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 3

First-pass working translation

The sun rose from the quiet sea and climbed the bronze sky,
shining upon the fields and on the walls of Pylos.
Telemachus and his companions drew near the shore,
where Nestor's people were sacrificing black bulls
to the dark-haired lord of the sea. Nine companies sat there,
five hundred men in each, and nine bulls lay ready.
Peisistratus saw the strangers first. Nestor's son came near,
and took them by the hand, inviting them to the feast.
He seated Telemachus beside himself upon the soft sand,
and placed before him the inward parts and a cup of wine.
Then he poured a libation and prayed to Poseidon:
“Hear us, lord of the sea. Grant a safe return to our friends,
and let these guests leave Pylos with what their hearts desire.
Give us, too, the grace of welcome, as they have received it.”
Nestor himself approached and spoke to them:
“Strangers, who are you? From where have you crossed the sea?
Do you wander for trade, or like pirates over the water,
who risk their lives and bring evil to foreign people?”
Telemachus answered with courage newly given:
“Nestor, son of Neleus, great glory of the Achaeans,
we come from Ithaca. We do not hide our purpose.
I seek a report of my father, if you have heard one.
He fought beside you when the Achaeans destroyed Troy.
We have heard of the deaths of other chiefs,
but no one can tell us where Odysseus went,
whether the earth holds him or the sea has swallowed him.
Therefore I have come to your knees, asking you to speak.”
Nestor answered: “You have brought back to my heart
the whole labor we endured beneath the walls of Priam.
If we had obeyed Odysseus in every danger, we should have
returned more quickly. He was the best in counsel and speech.
But let us eat first, and later I will tell all that I know.”
When they had eaten, the old king began:
“We Achaeans sat in Troy with the horse in our hands,

waiting for the hour of departure. Then Athena called us on,
and division entered the sons of Atreus. Menelaus wanted
to launch at once, but Agamemnon held the people back,
to sacrifice and appease the anger of Athena.
The two brothers argued. Night came, and we slept beside
the ships, though the evil mind of Menelaus kept watch.
At dawn he called the men who followed him, and took the sea.
I too launched my ships; Diomedes and Odysseus followed.
But Agamemnon remained, seeking to calm the people.
The sea was fair. I reached Tenedos and sacrificed to the gods,
then sailed onward. Diomedes came beside me; Odysseus turned
back to Agamemnon. Later I heard that he too had departed.
We reached Lesbos, and considered the long sea-road:
whether to pass above Chios, by Psyros and the open water,
or below Chios, beside the island of Mimas. We prayed,
and Zeus thundered; the sign showed us to cross the middle sea.
All night the oars moved. At dawn we saw the land of Euboea.
We passed swiftly by the headland of Geraestus and offered
a great thigh to Poseidon for saving us from the waves.
On the fourth day Diomedes reached Argos with his men.
I continued to Pylos, and no wind failed me. Since that time
I have heard little of those who were scattered. Yet the gods
have not hidden from me the names of the dead and returned:
Achilles lies beneath the earth; Patroclus too; Ajax has died;
and Agamemnon came home only to find a treacherous death.
Menelaus, who gathered many treasures, wandered far away.
If he had been present, you could ask him everything.
He was absent for a long time, driven by storm and hunger,
but he has come at last to Lacedaemon. Go there tomorrow,
and Peisistratus will guide you. Do not sleep in the ship;
come to my house, where there is room, and I will receive you.”
Telemachus said: “Nestor, it is right to obey you.
But I would rather sleep beside the ship tonight,
because I have left no guardian in Ithaca. If I should delay,
I may lose the chance to learn of my father.”
Athena then appeared in Mentor's form and spoke:
“Telemachus, do not remain here. We must reach the ship.
Let us go now, and ask your companions to make ready.

Nestor, send your son with us. Let him sleep on the shore,
and at dawn drive with us to Lacedaemon. He is young,
and a good guide beside the horses.”

Nestor knew the voice of the goddess, and answered:

“You speak like the immortals, Mentor. I will not delay you.

Peisistratus, yoke the smooth-haired horses to the chariot.

Bring the finest harness, and drive our guests to Sparta.”

They returned to the ship. Nestor's sons and companions
gave Telemachus gifts: a golden cup with two handles,
and a double vessel for libations. Athena stood by the stern,
and Nestor poured wine, lifting his hands to the sky:

“Hear me, daughter of Zeus, and grant these men safe passage.

Come to my house again when you return from Lacedaemon.”

The goddess heard him. The young men climbed aboard,
and the ship cut the dark water. All night they sailed,
while the stars turned above the mast and the sea breathed.

At dawn they reached the broad land of Laconia,
and came to the hollow of Lacedaemon, where the horses ran.

Peisistratus brought them to the house of Menelaus,
who was celebrating his son's marriage and his daughter's
departure. The hall was bright with torches and with gold.

The guests were eating when they saw the strangers.

Menelaus rose, went toward them, and took their hands.

“Do not stand outside,” he said. “Share our meal.

Afterward we will ask your names. A guest is sacred.”

Telemachus looked at the shining house, and whispered:

“Peisistratus, look upon this splendor. The roof shines
like the sun; no mortal could possess such wealth.”

Menelaus heard him: “Do not compare a man to Zeus.

I have wandered, suffered, and brought home these possessions.

Many were left behind, and I would gladly give all this gold
for one of the men who died beneath Troy, especially Odysseus.

I do not know whether he lives. His wife and his child
must grieve for him; and when I hear his name, sorrow comes.”

Helen entered from her fragrant chamber, looking like Artemis.

She knew Telemachus at once, though she had not seen him:

“Menelaus, can we doubt that this is Odysseus' son?

His eyes, his head, and the shape of his hands are his father's.

He was still a child when the army sailed, and now he comes to seek him. The grief of that house has made him a man.”

Menelaus replied: “I too have thought the same. No other son would carry the look of Odysseus into this hall.”

The old herald brought a silver basin and golden pitcher.

Helen washed Telemachus, then drew near with a marvelous drug, given her by Polydamna in Egypt, which stills the heart's pain.

She mixed it in the wine, so that no one who drank would weep, even if mother and father died, or brother or son before him.

She told the story of Odysseus in Troy:

“He entered the enemy city disguised as a beggar, bruised himself and wore a poor garment over his body.

No one knew him, but I knew him. I had long been troubled by my own error, and wished the Achaeans to go home.

I gave him a bath and clothing, and swore to keep him secret.

He killed many Trojans and carried knowledge to the camp.

When he returned, I praised him, though my heart knew him; and Helenus alone understood how much he had endured.”

Telemachus listened, but his eyes filled with tears.

As snow melts upon the high hills when the west wind blows, so the tears ran down his cheeks, and he hid his face.

Menelaus saw them and let the story end.

When morning came, Menelaus rose and spoke:

“Telemachus, do not remain here longer than you wish.

You seek your father, and I too would know where he is.

I cannot tell you that he is dead. I heard from Proteus, the old man of the sea, that Odysseus was held on an island by Calypso, who would not let him return. He had no ship, no companions, and no way across the water.

That is all I know. Yet the gods do not hate him utterly.

Go home, and wait for the hour they have appointed.”

Telemachus answered: “I will return, since you command it.

But give me a memory of your house, that I may carry it to my mother and my father's hall.”

Menelaus gave him a mixing bowl of silver, with a gold rim, and a cup of such beauty that Hephaestus might have made it.

Helen placed a woven robe upon his knees:

“Take this, dear child. Let it lie in your mother's chamber

until the day she gives you to a bride. Then let your wife wear it.
May your heart rejoice when you return to your father's house.”
They yoked the horses. Helen came forward with a prophetic word:
“Take this sign with you. As an eagle carrying a goose
comes down from the mountain to its nest, so your father,
after wandering long, will return, and make the suitors pay.
Even now he is near, preparing evil for them in his mind.”
They left the house and drove across the plain. The road
was long, but the day was bright, and the horses moved swiftly.
At sunset they reached Pherae, the house of Diocles,
son of Orsilochus, who welcomed them and gave them a bed.
At dawn they rose and continued toward Pylos and the sea.

Source range: Book 3. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 4

First-pass working translation

Telemachus and Nestor's son came to Lacedaemon,
and drove through the valley to the house of Menelaus.
They found the people gathered for the wedding feast
of the king's son and for his daughter's leaving home.
The hall shone with bronze and silver, and the servants moved
with bread and wine. The strangers stopped at the threshold.
The herald Eteoneus saw the horses and went to ask:
“Menelaus, two strangers have arrived. Their horses look
like the horses of kings. Shall we unyoke them?”
Menelaus answered: “Why ask? In former days, when we wandered,
we too depended on the welcome of another man's house.
Take the horses, and lead them to fodder. Bring the guests in.”
The servants unhitched the shining team. They brought Telemachus
and Peisistratus inside, beneath the high roof. When the king saw
the beauty of the hall, Telemachus stood astonished and silent.
He looked upon the light of the house, like one who enters heaven.
Menelaus led them to the baths. The women washed their hands
and bodies, and set clean garments upon them. They sat beside
the king, while a maid brought water in a golden vessel,
and poured it over their hands. A polished table followed.
Menelaus said: “Eat. Tomorrow we will ask who you are.
No guest should be questioned before he has tasted food.”
They ate. Menelaus looked at Telemachus and thought:
“Surely this is Odysseus' son. He has his head and eyes,
and the same quiet sorrow.” But he waited until after the meal.
Helen came from her room, looking like the archer Artemis.
She sat at the loom and spoke first:
“Menelaus, is this not the son of the man who suffered for you?
He has come to seek his father. Perhaps we should stop eating
and mourn the dead, or remember them as the gods allow.”
Telemachus wiped his tears, but kept them hidden in his cloak.
Menelaus answered: “I too have recognized him. Odysseus had
such hands, such feet, and such a sorrow held beneath his face.
Before Troy he pleaded with the leaders, though dust covered him;

then when he took up the spear he was terrible as a storm.”

Peisistratus spoke: “Do not make us weep while supper stands. There will be time to remember. Let us sleep, and speak at dawn.”

When the morning appeared, Menelaus came before his guests: “Telemachus, what brings you through the country? Is it public business, or a private need? Speak plainly; I will help if I can.”

Telemachus answered: “Son of Atreus, king of men, I come seeking news of my father. My house is being destroyed. The suitors consume our cattle and sheep, and press my mother to marry. Tell me whether Odysseus lives, or whether you heard of his death after the war.”

Menelaus sighed: “You have entered a house with the same grief. I will not hide what I know. We were held in Egypt by contrary winds. We had no water, and my men grew desperate. An old man of the sea told me how to escape, but first I had to seize him.”

“I hid beside the shore beneath the skins of four seals. Their smell was unbearable; the sea-born old man's flock returned and he counted them. When he lay among the skins, I seized him. He changed to lion, serpent, leopard, and tree; then water, fire, and a great river. I held him fast, until he resumed his own body and answered me.”

“I asked which god delayed our return. He said Poseidon was angry. I had failed to sacrifice, and must return to Egypt, then cross the sea again and offer a hecatomb. He told me the fates of the other leaders: Ajax had died, and Agamemnon was murdered by Aegisthus. But he also told me that Odysseus was alive, held by Calypso on her island, with no ship or companions.”

Telemachus heard, and his heart was lifted, though grief remained. Helen mixed wine with a drug from Egypt that calms sorrow, then spoke of the wooden horse:

“When the best of the Achaeans sat hidden within it, I came around the hollow body, perhaps urged by a god. I called the names of the men inside, imitating their wives. Diomedes and Odysseus held them back. But your father heard my voice and knew the trap; he would not answer me. Only Anticlus desired to speak. Odysseus closed his hand over the man's mouth and kept all alive.”

Menelaus added: “I remember how Odysseus entered Troy

disguised as a slave. He beat himself, covered his shoulders with a filthy cloth, and carried a sharp sword beneath it. He returned with knowledge, and killed many enemies. Helen alone recognized him, but she kept the secret.”

Telemachus said: “Your words have given me what I came for. Now I must return to Ithaca before the suitors discover my absence.”

Menelaus offered him gifts: a mixing bowl of silver and gold, a double cup, and a robe Helen had woven with her own hands. “Keep this for your bride,” she said, “when you come to marriage. Let it lie in your mother's chamber until that day.”

Telemachus replied: “I thank you. May the gods grant me a return, and may my father hear that I have crossed the sea seeking him.”

Meanwhile the suitors in Ithaca noticed the empty house. They gathered in the place where they played and feasted, and Antinous spoke among them:

“Telemachus has gone, and this is not a little matter. He has taken a ship and the best companions of the island. We must kill him before he returns, or he will call an assembly and bring the people against us. Let us choose an ambush.”

Amphinomus, who had more sense than the others, said: “Would you kill a prince? First ask Zeus for a sign. If the god approves, I will strike him myself; if not, abandon it.”

Antinous rejected this: “Do not speak of restraint. The boy will return with the knowledge of his father, and then none of us will escape. Let the ship wait between Ithaca and Samos, at the strait where he must pass.”

They chose twenty men and sailed out. Their ship hid in a cove, watching the channels. The herald Medon had overheard them; he came to Penelope and told her of the plot. She climbed to the upper chamber, washed her face, and prayed to Athena:

“Daughter of Zeus, if Odysseus ever burned pleasing thighs for you in Troy, remember his son. Do not let the suitors kill him. I am left alone, and my heart is full of fear.”

Athena heard her prayer. She shaped a phantom like Iphthime, sister of Penelope, and sent it through the doors of sleep. The phantom stood beside the bed and said:

“Why do you grieve? Telemachus is under the gods' protection.

Athena watches him. She will not let the suitors prevail.”
Penelope answered: “If only dreams would speak clearly.
Some are empty, born from the gate of ivory; others from horn,
and those carry truth. I fear this dream may be false.”
The image faded, and she slept again. The suitors waited at sea,
while Telemachus and Nestor's son drove toward Pylos.
Athena walked beside the hidden young traveler, and night
covered the roads, the palace, and the ships that carried danger.

Source range: Book 4. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 5

First-pass working translation

The gods sat in council, and Athena spoke once more
for the man whose homecoming had been delayed so long.
Zeus sent Hermes to Calypso's island, Ogygia,
where the nymph kept Odysseus in a hollow cave.
Hermes bound his golden sandals beneath his feet,
and took the wand that puts men to sleep or wakes them.
He flew across the sea, like a gull that skims the waves,
then stood before the cave, where the fire burned bright.
Calypso sang within, moving beside the loom;
the sweet smoke rose from cedar and juniper. Hermes saw her,
and she knew the messenger of Zeus. She offered him food,
but he answered: "I did not come by my own desire.
Who would cross this salt waste willingly? Zeus sent me.
He says you must release Odysseus. His fate is not to die here.
He must return to his house and see his friends again."
Calypso replied: "Cruel gods, jealous beyond all others,
you cannot bear to see a goddess share her bed with a mortal.
Yet when a god takes a mortal woman to his own embrace,
you do not punish him. You remember Orion and Dawn;
you remember Demeter. Why is my love called a crime?
Odysseus has no ship, no companions, and no way to leave.
I cannot send him over the sea without ruin."
Hermes answered: "Do not oppose the will of Zeus.
His anger reaches farther than the sea. Obey, and let him go."
The messenger departed. Calypso found Odysseus seated
upon the shore, looking across the water until his eyes failed.
He wept, because the nymph no longer gave him joy.
She came near and spoke:
"Unhappy man, do not wear your life away in grief.
I will release you. Cut timber, join it with pegs and ropes,
and build a broad raft. I will give you bread, water, and wine,
and clothes against the cold. I will send a following wind.
If the gods who hold the sky are willing, you will reach your land."
Odysseus answered warily: "You are planning something else.

You ask me to cross the sea on a raft, where even a ship
would suffer, and you say the gods are willing. I will not go
unless you swear that no further evil waits beneath your promise.”
Calypso smiled, and swore the great oath of the gods.
She led him to the forest's edge, where tall trees grew,
and gave him bronze axes, a sharp adze, and a smooth auger.
Odysseus felled twenty trees, trimmed them, and squared them.
He bored the beams and joined them tightly, as a shipwright does.
Calypso brought a great sail and made the mast-cloth ready.
He built a deck, raised bulwarks against the waves,
and wove a fence of branches around the raft. She carried
skins of water, bread, wine, and a dark cloak against the wind.
On the fourth day the work was finished. On the fifth,
Calypso bathed him, clothed him, and led him to the shore.
She placed two skins of wine and water aboard, and a sack
of provisions. The wind blew gently from the west.
“Go,” she said. “May your return be granted. Remember me,
though I have been your sorrow, and know that no one will love
you more deeply or more faithfully than I have loved you.”
Odysseus replied: “Do not be angry. I know how greatly
Penelope is less than you in form and stature. She is mortal,
and you are deathless, untouched by age. Yet I long each day
to reach my home and see the hour of return. If the gods
send me another trial, I will endure it. I have suffered much.”
He took the steering oar and pushed the raft out.
For seventeen days he crossed the open water, watching
the stars. On the eighteenth he saw the mountains of Scheria,
dark as a shield upon the horizon. He was near the land
of the Phaeacians, who lived beyond the sea's deep current.
Poseidon returned from the Ethiopians and saw Odysseus.
He shook his head and said: “The gods have changed their minds.
He is close to the Phaeacians, where fate says he shall escape.
But I will give him more suffering before he reaches them.”
He gathered the clouds and stirred the sea. Eurys and Notus,
Zephyr and the north wind struck together, and the wave rose.
Odysseus' knees grew weak. He said:
“Three and four times happy were the men who died at Troy.
I wish I had fallen there, beneath the bronze of the Trojans.”

Then the Achaeans would have buried me, and my fame would stand.
Now the sea will carry me nameless away.”

The wind tore the sail. The mast split, and the raft broke.

Odysseus was thrown into the waves. He tied a leather strap
around himself and remained among the wreckage, as a man
who has been crushed by a roof clings to a single beam.

Ino, once a mortal woman and now a sea goddess, saw him.

She rose like a gull above the water, and spoke:

“Poor man, why has Poseidon made you suffer so?

Take this immortal veil. Bind it beneath your chest.

When you reach land, throw it into the sea, turning your face away.

It will carry you through the waves. Do not fear death.”

Odysseus wondered whether another god was setting a snare.

But when the raft disappeared and the waves closed above it,
he bound the veil and entered the water. Athena calmed the winds,
though the sea still rose high beneath him.

For two days and two nights he swam, seeing no shore.

On the third dawn the wind fell, and he heard breakers near land.

He saw the coast, but reefs and cliffs stood around it.

The waves threw him against the rock; he would have died,
but Athena gave him strength to seize an outer stone.

He was swept back into the deep. His skin was torn,
and the sea stripped him of breath. He swam along the coast,
seeking a river mouth where the current might bear him inland.

At last he found a stream that ran quietly into the sea.

He prayed to the river:

“Hear me, lord, whoever you are. I come to you as a suppliant,
fleeing the anger of Poseidon. The deathless gods respect
the man who wanders and suffers. Let me reach your bank.”

The river held back its current and stilled the waves.

Odysseus entered, and his knees gave way. The water carried him
into the reeds. He vomited salt from his lungs and lay without
breath. Athena withdrew the sea's force, and he crawled inland.

He untied Ino's veil and cast it into the current. The wave
carried it out, and Ino received it again. Odysseus dragged
himself beneath two bushes that grew from one root,
an olive and a wild olive, dense enough to hide him from view.

There he gathered leaves in his arms and made a bed. He piled

so many upon himself that a man in winter would not welcome
the shelter more gratefully. Athena poured sleep upon his eyes,
to end the exhaustion, while the sea moved below the shore.

Source range: Book 5. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 6

First-pass working translation

Athena went to the land of the Phaeacians, and entered the dream of Nausicaa, daughter of Alcinous, whose house ruled the people. She took the form of a girl she loved, the daughter of Dymas, and stood beside the bed of the princess:

“Nausicaa, why has your mother brought you into the world with garments unwoven and unwashed? Your wedding day is near, and you must have beautiful clothes, as must those who attend you. Ask your father for a wagon at dawn, with a high chest, so that you may wash the robes and shining cloaks.”

When the bright-eyed goddess had spoken, she went to Olympus. Nausicaa woke, and wondered at the dream. She went to her parents, and said to her father: “Dear father, have the wagon made ready.

I have soiled garments lying in the house. I should wash them.

You too must wear clean clothes when you sit among the chiefs.

My five brothers go to the dance, but they do not think of this.”

She was ashamed to name marriage before her father;

he understood, and answered: “I will not refuse you. The young men will prepare the wagon and the mules.”

They brought the wagon, and Nausicaa's mother placed in it fine clothes, oil, and food. Her father gave her wine and water.

At dawn she and the maidens drove toward the river mouth, where the water was deep enough to wash and the shore smooth.

They unloaded the robes, trampled them in the dark water, and spread them upon the stones to dry beneath the sun.

After bathing and anointing themselves, they ate beside the river, then played ball. Nausicaa threw it beyond one maiden; the girl cried out, and the sound woke Odysseus.

He had slept beneath the leaves, covered in sea-salt and grime.

He rose, and broke a branch from the thicket to hide himself.

Like a mountain lion driven by hunger, he came out of the wood, wet with brine and terrible to see. The girls fled in every direction.

Only Nausicaa remained, because Athena put courage in her heart.

Odysseus stood apart and spoke carefully:

“Are you a goddess or a mortal? If you are a goddess,

you resemble Artemis, daughter of Zeus, in height and beauty.
 If you are mortal, three times happy are your father and mother,
 and three times happy the brothers who rejoice when you dance.
 But happiest of all is the man whose gifts win you as his wife.
 I have suffered much. I came from the sea, and the waves
 have cast me upon this shore. I have no cloak, no city,
 no knowledge of where I am. Give me a rag to cover myself,
 and show me the road to your town. May the gods grant you
 whatever your heart desires: husband, house, and concord within it.”
 Nausicaa answered: “Stranger, you are not wicked or foolish.
 Zeus gives fortune to good and bad alike. He has given you grief.
 Since you have reached our land, you shall not lack clothing.
 I will show you the city, for we are Phaeacians, and this is
 the kingdom of Alcinous, my father.”
 She told the maidens to stand, saying: “Why do you run?
 Do you think he is an enemy? No mortal man could attack us here;
 the deathless gods protect our island. He is a poor wanderer,
 and Zeus sends strangers and beggars to us. Give him food and drink.
 Wash him in the river, where he is sheltered from the wind.”
 The girls returned. They gave Odysseus food and wine,
 and laid clean clothing before him. He washed himself apart,
 because he did not want the maidens to see his nakedness.
 Athena made him appear larger and more beautiful;
 his hair fell in curls like hyacinth upon his head.
 Nausicaa looked at him and said to the maidens:
 “Would that a man like this might be called my husband,
 living here among us. Give him food and fill the jars.”
 Odysseus ate and drank, for he had gone long without nourishment.
 The maidens folded the garments and loaded the wagon.
 Nausicaa then spoke to him:
 “Rise, stranger. We must go to the city. I will tell you
 how to approach my father. Beyond the fields is a grove
 of poplars sacred to Athena, beside a spring. Wait there
 until we have reached the house. When you think we are within,
 enter the city and ask for the palace of Alcinous.
 It is easy to recognize. No other house is so bright.
 When you enter, go straight to my mother and clasp her knees.
 If she receives you kindly, you may hope to see your friends

and reach your home, however far it lies.”

“But do not follow beside our wagon. People talk.

They would say, ‘Who is this stranger walking with Nausicaa? Where did she find him?’ I would be ashamed. Let them speak when I am already home. My brothers are quick to anger.”

Odysseus answered: “I will do as you say. I would not have you hear a word that causes pain. May Artemis grant you a husband who pleases you, and may your father and mother rejoice.”

The sun declined. The wagon reached Athena’s grove.

Odysseus sat beneath the olive trees and prayed:

“Hear me, daughter of Zeus. You once guided me at Troy.

Now make the Phaeacians pity me, and let their king receive me.”

Athena heard him, but did not appear openly, because Poseidon was still angry. She entered the city and strengthened the heart of Nausicaa’s father, so that he would welcome the stranger.

Nausicaa returned to the palace. Her brothers lifted the robes from the wagon, and her mother set them in a chest. The princess went to her chamber, where her nurse lit a fire beside her.

Odysseus waited until the maidens were gone. He wrapped himself in the woven cloak and entered the city. Athena spread mist around him so that no one would hinder him. She appeared as a young girl carrying a water jar, and Odysseus asked:

“Child, can you show me the house of Alcinous? I am a stranger from far away, cast here by the sea. I do not know the roads.”

Athena answered: “I will show you. The palace is near my own house. Follow me silently. Do not speak to the people; they are cautious with foreigners. The Phaeacians do not welcome every man alike, for they live apart beside the sea.”

She showed him the splendid house, and told him its wonders:

the bronze walls, golden doors, silver doorposts, and golden handles;

the dogs of gold and silver fashioned by Hephaestus;

the benches covered with woven cloth, where the chiefs sat;

the boys bearing torches in the night; the orchards that never failed.

“Enter,” she said. “You must clasp the knees of the queen.

Her name is Arete, and she is honored like a god. She has wisdom, and all your hope depends upon her.”

Athena vanished. Odysseus entered the house of Alcinous.

He stood before the hearth, where Arete sat beside the fire.

He clasped her knees and prayed:

“Queen, after many sufferings I have come to your house.

May the gods grant you happiness, children, and concord.

Give me passage home, for I have been long from my country.”

He sat among the ashes. The hall became silent. Echeneus,
oldest of the Phaeacians, spoke:

“It is not right that a stranger sit upon the ground.

Raise him, and give him a place beside the hearth.”

Alcinous lifted Odysseus and seated him in the chair

of his own son. The herald poured water over his hands;

the servants brought bread and meat. The king addressed the people:

“Tomorrow let us launch a ship and prepare a feast.

We will send our guest home, for he has suffered greatly.

Let us not delay a man whom the gods have brought to us.”

Arete recognized the clothing Odysseus wore. She asked:

“Stranger, who gave you these garments? Did you come from the sea
as you stand now, or did someone clothe you?”

Odysseus answered: “I will tell you the truth. Calypso held me

on her island, but Zeus commanded my release. I built a raft,

and Poseidon broke it beneath me. I swam until I reached your shore.

Your daughter and her maidens were washing clothes by the river.

She gave me this cloak and told me to seek your knees.”

Alcinous answered: “My daughter did not act as she should,

for she ought to have brought you home with her companions.

But you shall not lack help. I will give you a ship and men.”

He promised to make Odysseus' return the care of the Phaeacians.

Odysseus slept beneath the portico, while Arete and Alcinous

went to their chamber. Outside, the sea moved under the stars.

Source range: Book 6. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 7

First-pass working translation

Odysseus slept beneath Athena's grove. The goddess went into the city,
to the palace of Alcinous, where the Phaeacian chiefs were assembled.
She entered the chamber of Nausicaa, and spoke as a friend:
"Your robes lie ready, but you have not told your mother
where they are. Go to the palace. Ask for a fine chest,
and help the women prepare your wedding garments."
Nausicaa woke, amazed by the dream. Athena crossed the city,
then returned to the shore, where Odysseus still lay asleep.
She poured mist around him, and waited for his waking.
Odysseus rose and looked toward the town. Athena took the form
of a young girl, and he asked her the road to Alcinous' house.
She led him through the mist, describing the palace:
bronze walls, golden doors, silver doorposts, and dogs of gold,
made by Hephaestus with deathless craft. Orchards grew within,
where fruit never failed, and the trees bore in every season.
"Enter," she said. "Find Queen Arete. Hold her knees.
She is wise, and the Phaeacians obey her as much as the king.
If she welcomes you, your homecoming is assured."
Then she vanished into the darkness. Odysseus entered the palace.
He crossed the threshold unseen, and clasped the knees of Arete.
He prayed: "After many sufferings, I come to your house.
May the gods grant your husband and children joy.
Give me a ship, and let me see my homeland again."
He sat among the ashes. The hall fell silent. Echeneus, oldest
of the people, said: "It is not right for a stranger to sit in dust.
Alcinous, raise him and give him a chair beside the hearth."
The king lifted Odysseus and seated him in the shining chair.
The herald poured water upon his hands, and servants set food before him.
Alcinous spoke to the council:
"Tomorrow choose a ship and a crew. We will send this man home,
wherever his country lies. Our people have always been guides
across the sea. Let no stranger leave us without the return he needs."
Arete looked at the cloak and shirt upon Odysseus:
"Stranger, who gave you these garments? Did you come from the sea

wearing them, or did someone clothe you on the shore?"

Odysseus told the truth: "Calypso kept me in her island cave. Zeus commanded her to release me. I built a raft, but Poseidon broke it in the storm. I swam to your shore. Nausicaa found me by the river, and gave me these clothes. She told me to seek you."

The king said: "My daughter should have brought you home herself, but you must not blame her. She may have feared the talk of the people. You will have a ship, and a safe escort, unless you desire to remain."

Odysseus answered: "Do not offer me a choice. My heart has long desired home. I would rather die upon the road than live forever without seeing my wife and the smoke rising from Ithaca."

The queen recognized the work of her own hands in his garments, and wondered. Odysseus had spoken, but he kept his name hidden. When the assembly ended, the king directed the herald to prepare a bed beneath the portico. Odysseus lay down among the warm blankets. The queen and king returned to their chamber; before they slept, Alcinous said:

"Arete, this stranger is noble in body and speech. He resembles the deathless ones. I would have him marry Nausicaa and remain here, but if he wishes to go, we must not hold him. Tomorrow give him gifts."

Arete answered: "Do not decide before we know his name and country. His clothing tells me only that he has suffered in our world."

Odysseus heard them, and sleep finally came over him. At dawn Alcinous called the Phaeacian people to assembly. He stood among them and spoke:

"This stranger has come to my house. I do not know whether he is from the east or west, but he asks for a ship. Let us grant it. Choose a vessel, and gather the rowers. Prepare a feast in my hall."

The people went to the harbor. The ship was drawn down, and twenty-two men were chosen. They raised the mast, fastened the sail, and placed the oars in their leather thongs. Alcinous led the chiefs to the palace. He ordered an ox sacrificed to Zeus, lord of travelers, and the servants prepared the meal. Demodocus, the singer, was brought into the hall. He was blind, but the Muse had given him song, and he knew the griefs of men. After the feast the games began. Laodamas called on Odysseus:

"Stranger, come and test yourself. You should not remain seated. Tell us what contests you have known; your body shows that you have."

Odysseus replied: “You speak without kindness. I have suffered at sea; I am weakened by hunger and sorrow. Do not press me into a contest.”

Euryalus insulted him: “You look like a merchant, not an athlete, someone who watches his cargo and counts his profit.”

Odysseus looked at him and said: “You have spoken badly.

No man is pleasing in every gift. I am not skilled in all contests, but I will not endure your words.”

He seized a great discus, heavier and larger than the Phaeacian stones, and threw it far beyond the mark. The people cried out.

He said: “Now call the fastest man, and the best wrestler, if you wish to prove whether a stranger is weak.”

Alcinous stopped the contest and praised the guest:

“Our people are not the strongest boxers or wrestlers, but we are swift runners, sailors, and dancers. Let us show him our gifts, so that he will remember us when he reaches home.”

The young men danced. Demodocus sang of Ares and Aphrodite, and of the net Hephaestus laid around the lovers. The people laughed, but Odysseus watched the song as a man watches a wound.

Alcinous gave Euryalus a sword and told him to make peace.

The young man approached Odysseus and offered a golden gift:

“Forgive my words. I spoke from foolishness.”

The queen brought out a chest for the clothes, and the king ordered the gifts packed: gold, bronze, and woven garments. Odysseus thanked them, and urged the servants to store the treasure beside the ship.

When evening came, the Phaeacians poured wine to Zeus and prepared the final meal. Odysseus asked that Demodocus sing of the wooden horse, the stratagem by which the Achaeans entered Troy.

The singer began. He told how Odysseus stood in the assembly, how the horse was drawn into the city, and how the hidden men climbed out at night. Odysseus covered his face and wept.

Alcinous saw the tears and told the singer to stop.

“The stranger weeps whenever the song turns toward Troy.

Tomorrow he must tell us his name and country, and the grief that has followed him across the sea.”

The hall grew quiet. The night held the guest beneath its roof, and the ship waited beside the water for the promised departure.

Source range: Book 7. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 8

First-pass working translation

When dawn appeared, Alcinous called the Phaeacians to assembly.
He spoke: “Let us send our guest home. Choose a ship,
and let the rowers make her ready. We will hold a feast,
and the elders will come. We must honor the stranger.”
The people went to the shore. They drew a black ship down,
raised her mast, fixed the sail, and carried provisions aboard.
Then they returned to the king's house and filled the hall.
Alcinous ordered an ox sacrificed to Zeus, lord of travelers.
The servants prepared the meal. The singer Demodocus came,
beloved of the Muse, though she had taken his sight and given song.
After they had eaten, Alcinous said: “Let us go to the games.
Our guest should know what the Phaeacians can do.” They went
to the open place, and the young men competed in running,
wrestling, boxing, jumping, and throwing the discus.
Laodamas called to Odysseus: “Will you not join us? Your body
shows that you have known hardship. There is no greater shame
than refusing a contest among friends.”
Odysseus answered: “You have not spoken kindly. I did not come
to compete; sorrow and the sea have weakened me.”
Euryalus insulted him, calling him a merchant who cared only
for cargo. Odysseus lifted a heavy discus and threw it beyond
the mark. It struck the earth with a deep sound.
“I am not skilled in every contest,” he said, “but I am not last
among men. Call your best runner, your strongest wrestler,
or your boxer. I will answer the insult, though I sit among guests.”
Alcinous calmed them: “Our people are not famous for fighting.
We are swift runners, sailors, and dancers. Let us show our gifts.”
Euryalus gave Odysseus a sword and apologized. Odysseus accepted.
The young men danced, and Demodocus sang of the gods:
how Ares loved Aphrodite, though she was the wife of Hephaestus;
how the Sun saw them and told the craftsman; how he forged
a net finer than a spider's thread and caught the lovers in bed.
The gods laughed around them, and the tale ended in shame.
Then Alcinous asked Demodocus to sing of the wooden horse,

the horse Odysseus had brought to Troy. The singer began:
“The Argives built the hollow horse and filled it with the best.
The Trojans dragged it within their city, while the army hid
behind the wall. The city debated. Some wished to break it open;
others said it was a gift for Athena. At last the horse stood
before the temple, carrying death within its carved body.
At night Odysseus and his companions climbed out. They killed
the guards and opened the gates. The Achaean army entered,
and Troy burned.”

Odysseus covered his face and wept. He wept as a woman weeps
over her husband, fallen before his city while its people flee.
No one saw the tears but Alcinous, who sat beside him and heard.
He stopped the singer and told the company:

“Let Demodocus cease. Our guest has suffered in this war.
Tomorrow he must tell us his name and country. Let us not make
his grief endless, for strangers and beggars are all under Zeus.”
Alcinous then asked for contests again. Clytoneus won the foot race;
Euryalus won the boxing; Amphialus won the leap; Elatreus the discus;
Laodamas the wrestling. The young men stood proud, but the king
called Odysseus among them:

“You have seen our games. We ask only that you join the dance.”
They danced in pairs, and Demodocus sang of the war god and goddess.
The song ended. Alcinous gave the guest a golden cup and garments.
Each chief added a gift. Euryalus presented a sword, saying:
“Take this, and let the earlier insult be forgotten.”

The queen sent her attendants for a great chest. She placed within it
the clothing and gold. Alcinous ordered a blanket and a cloak,
and told the king's son to tie them aboard, so the guest's sleep
would be safe upon the ship.

When evening came, the Phaeacians returned to the palace.
The servants set meat and wine before Odysseus. He asked Demodocus:
“Sing of the wooden horse again, and of the moment when Odysseus
led it into Troy. Tell how the Achaeans stood around it,
and how the city received the gift.”

The singer obeyed. Odysseus wept again, and Alcinous saw it.
The king addressed him:
“Tell me why the song of Troy brings such sorrow. Did someone
die there who was dear to you? A father, brother, or companion?”

We have heard that the Achaeans suffered much, but you seem to know the weight of every name.”

Odysseus answered: “Alcinous, you have spoken wisely.

There is no greater honor than hearing a singer who knows the order of events and makes them live again. Tell your people to ready the ship. I will speak my name, my country, and the trials that have carried me so far from home.”

He rose, and the hall grew still. The fire burned in the hearth; outside, the sea moved beneath the moon. The Phaeacians waited for the man of many turnings to begin his own story.

Source range: Book 8. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 9

First-pass working translation

Odysseus answered Alcinous: “You ask me my name and country.
I am Odysseus, son of Laertes, known to men for many turns.
I live in Ithaca, beneath Mount Neriton. It is rough, but dear.
No place is sweeter to a man than his own land and people.
Now hear the griefs I carried home from Troy. The Cicones lived
near Ismarus. I sacked their city, killed the men, and divided
the women and goods among my companions. I told them to leave,
but they would not listen. The Cicones called neighboring warriors.
At dawn they came upon us, more numerous than autumn leaves.
We fought, but six men from each ship fell, and the rest escaped.
The gods sent a north wind against us. For two days we stayed
beside the shore, with little food. On the third, we raised the mast
and sailed. At Malea the current and storms drove us beyond Crete.
For nine days we wandered; on the tenth we reached the land
of the Lotus-eaters, who eat a flower that makes a man forget home.
Some of my companions tasted it, and no longer wished to return.
They wanted only to remain among the Lotus-eaters. I dragged them
back to the ships, bound them beneath the benches, and ordered
the others to row, lest they too forget the day of return.
We reached the land of the Cyclopes, a people who trust the gods
and do not plant or plow. Grain grows wild; vines grow without care.
They have no assemblies, no laws, and no city. Each rules his family
from a cave upon the mountain, without concern for the others.
We landed on an island opposite their shore. Wild goats filled it.
We hunted, ate, and slept. At dawn we crossed to the mainland,
and saw a vast cave near the sea. We found cheese and pens of sheep,
but my companions urged me to take the food and go.
I refused. I wanted to meet the cave's master, and see what gift
he would offer a stranger. We entered, lit a fire, ate the cheese,
and waited. At evening the Cyclops came, carrying dry wood.
He was enormous, like a mountain walking. He rolled a stone
across the doorway that twenty-two wagons could not move.
He milked his sheep, then saw us. “Strangers, who are you?
Are you traders, or do you wander the sea like pirates?”

I answered: "We are Achaeans from Troy. We seek your knees,
and ask the hospitality that Zeus protects. We are shipwrecked."
He replied: "You are fools, or come from far away, to ask me
about Zeus. Cyclopes do not care for Zeus or the other gods.
Tell me where you left your ship."
I concealed the truth: "Poseidon destroyed it against the rocks.
We escaped from the sea." The Cyclops seized two men and smashed
them against the ground. He ate them like a lion, leaving nothing.
Then he lay among his sheep and slept.
I thought of drawing my sword, but we could not move the stone.
We would die beside the bodies. So I waited for dawn.
The Cyclops milked his sheep, and again seized two companions.
He ate them and drove the flock out, leaving us in darkness.
I found a stake of green olive, long and thick. I cut it down,
smoothed it, sharpened the end, and hardened it in the fire.
We drew lots. Four men would help me. At night the Cyclops returned,
and again devoured two. I brought him a bowl of dark wine:
"Cyclops, drink this wine. It will reward you for the flesh you ate.
You will know what kind of cargo our ship carried. We called you
our host, but your violence has made your house a place of death."
He drank and asked for more: "Give it freely, and I will give you
a gift. Tell me your name."
I answered: "My name is Nobody. My father and friends call me Nobody."
He replied: "Nobody I will eat last, and that shall be your gift."
The wine overcame him, and he fell asleep. We heated the stake
in the fire, and when its tip glowed, we drove it into his eye.
I pressed and twisted it, as a shipwright turns an auger in timber.
Blood boiled, and the hot eye hissed. The Cyclops cried out,
and the other Cyclopes came from their caves:
"What troubles you, Polyphemus? Is someone stealing your sheep?"
He shouted: "Nobody is killing me by deceit!"
They answered: "If Nobody attacks you, you are sick. Pray to Poseidon."
Then they left. I laughed inwardly at the name and its success.
The Cyclops pulled the stake from his eye and groped toward the door.
He rolled the stone aside and sat in the entrance, feeling each sheep,
thinking we might escape beneath their wool. I tied the rams together,
three by three, and fixed one man beneath the middle ram.
For myself I chose the largest, and clung beneath his belly.

At dawn the flock moved out. The Cyclops felt their backs,
but did not search below. The great ram paused at the doorway.
Polyphemus spoke to him:
“Why are you last today? You have always led the flock.
Do you grieve for your master's eye, blinded by a wicked man?
If you could speak, you would tell me where he hides.”
He let the ram pass. I slipped free and released the others.
We drove the sheep to the ship, and called those remaining by name.
We loaded them, raised the sail, and rowed from shore.
When we were twice as far as a calling voice can carry,
I called back: “Cyclops, no weak man blinded you. It was Odysseus,
son of Laertes, whose home is Ithaca!”
He tore the crown from a mountain and threw it. The sea rose,
and the wave drove our ship back toward land. My companions restrained me.
I called again: “If anyone asks who blinded you, tell them the truth.”
Polyphemus prayed to Poseidon: “Hear me. If Odysseus reaches home,
let him return late, alone, and in another man's ship. Let him find
trouble in his house.” Poseidon heard him.
We escaped to the island, divided the sheep, and made sacrifice.
The gods accepted the smoke, but Zeus did not. At night we slept;
at dawn we sailed onward, carrying the memory of the blinded giant.

Source range: Book 9. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 10

First-pass working translation

We reached the island of Aeolus, keeper of the winds.
He lived in a floating palace with his wife and children,
and the gods had made him master of every storm. For a month
he asked me about Troy, the sea, and the return of the Achaeans.
When I asked to leave, he gave me a bag made from an ox's hide.
Within it he had bound every adverse wind. He let the west wind blow,
the wind that would carry us home. I tied the bag beneath the ship's bench,
and for nine days we sailed. On the tenth, Ithaca appeared.
I saw the fires of my homeland. Then sleep overcame me.
My companions whispered: "He has brought home gold and silver,
while we have received nothing. Open the bag. Perhaps treasure lies within."
They loosed the hide. The winds burst out, and a storm seized us.
We were driven back toward Aeolus' island. I woke and considered
whether to throw myself into the sea. I remained, hoping for the land.
We begged Aeolus to help us again. He asked: "Have the gods pursued you?
Did you offend them?" I said no. He replied: "Then go. I cannot aid
a man whom the blessed gods hate." So he sent us away.
We rowed six days and came to the land of the Laestrygonians.
Their harbor was narrow, ringed by cliffs, with one entrance.
I kept my own ship outside and tied her to a rock; the others entered.
A girl carrying water saw us and led the men to her father.
When the king came, he was vast as a mountain. He seized one companion
and devoured him. The others cried out. The Laestrygonians gathered,
throwing stones from the cliffs. They smashed the ships like pots,
spearred the men, and carried them home as food.
I cut the cable of my ship and urged the rowers to pull.
We escaped, but all the other ships were lost. Only mine remained.
We reached Aea, the island of Circe, and landed in silence.
For two days we lay in grief. On the third, I climbed a hill and saw
smoke rising from the forest. I divided the men into two companies.
Eurylocus led the first; I remained with the other.
Circe welcomed Eurylocus and his men into her house. She mixed wine
with honey and cheese, and touched each man with her wand.
They became pigs—heads, bristles, and voices still human—and she shut

them in her pens. Eurylocus escaped and told me.
I took my sword and bow, but Hermes met me on the road. He gave me
the herb moly, black at the root and white as milk, which resists
Circe's spell. "When she strikes you," he said, "rush upon her.
She will ask you to share her bed. Make her swear not to harm you."
I entered the house. Circe offered the cup. I drank, but her wand
could not change me. I drew my sword and rushed at her.
She clasped my knees: "Who are you? No man has resisted this cup.
You must be the Odysseus Hermes foretold, on his way home from Troy.
Put away your sword. Let us become friends."
I made her swear the great oath that no further evil would follow.
Then she released my companions and restored them to human shape.
They looked younger and stronger than before, and wept to see me.
Circe welcomed all the rest of the company. For a year we lived
in her house, eating meat and sweet wine, but my companions reminded me:
"The hour of return is near. You must not forget Ithaca."
I asked Circe to send us home. She answered: "You cannot return
until you have gone to the house of Hades and Persephone,
to ask the blind prophet Tiresias. I will tell you the road.
The north wind will carry you to Oceanus; there you must beach the ship.
Dig a trench, pour offerings of milk, honey, wine, and water,
and sprinkle barley. Pray to the dead, then sacrifice black sheep.
The shades will gather. Let only Tiresias drink the blood."
My companions lamented, but Circe gave us provisions and a ram,
and set a following wind behind the ship. We raised the sail,
and the night carried us away from the island of enchantment.

Source range: Book 10. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 11

First-pass working translation

We came to the river Ocean, where the Cimmerian people live,
hidden beneath mist and night. The sun never shines upon them;
the darkness holds them, whether dawn rises or evening falls.
We drew the ship onto the shore and followed Circe's directions.
I dug a trench and poured offerings to all the dead: milk and honey,
wine, and water over barley. I prayed to the shades and promised
a barren heifer when I reached Ithaca. Then I cut the throats
of two black sheep. The blood ran into the trench.
The dead gathered. Women, old men, warriors, and children came,
all crying, and I feared their hollow voices. I kept them from the blood
until Tiresias should drink. Elpenor came first, the companion
who had died on Circe's roof. He begged for burial:
“Do not leave me unwept and unburied. Burn me with my armor,
raise a mound beside the sea, and set my oar upon it,
so men unborn may know the rower who died before his time.”
I promised him. Then I allowed Tiresias to drink. The blind prophet
held the golden staff, and spoke:
“You seek the path home, but Poseidon will make it hard.
You blinded his son, and the god will not forget. Still, you may arrive
if you and your companions leave the cattle of the Sun untouched.
If you harm them, you will lose your ship and all your men.
You alone will return, late, and in another's vessel.
When you have killed the suitors and restored your house,
take an oar and travel inland, where men do not know the sea.
When someone asks why you carry a winnowing fan upon your shoulder,
plant the oar in the earth and sacrifice to Poseidon.
Then death will come to you from the sea, gentle and complete.”
I asked about my mother. Tiresias said she still sat in sorrow
within the house, waiting for me. He vanished after drinking.
I let my mother approach the blood. She drank and recognized me.
“My child,” she cried, “how have you come beneath the darkness?
Are you dead? The living do not visit this place.”
I answered: “I have not yet entered Hades. I came to ask Tiresias
the road home. I have not touched Ithaca. I still wander.”

She said: “Your father has withdrawn to the country, grieving.
He no longer sleeps in the town. Penelope waits in the hall,
and your son Telemachus holds the house, though the suitors consume it.
As for me, I died from longing for you, not from a disease.”

I tried to embrace her. Three times I reached, and three times
she slipped through my hands like a shadow. I asked why the dead
could not be held. She answered: “When a man dies, sinews fail,
and the bones no longer hold flesh. Fire consumes the body;
the spirit flies like a dream.”

Then I saw a procession of famous women and asked their names:
Tyro, Antiope, Alcmene, Epicaste, Chloris, Leda, Iphimedeia,
Phaedra, Procris, Ariadne, Maera, Clymene, and Eriphyle.
They had borne sons and founded houses, but death received them all.
I saw Orion pursuing the beasts he once hunted. Tityus lay stretched
across the ground, while vultures tore his liver, which grew again.
Tantalus stood in water up to his chin, but thirst drove him
from every drink; fruit hung above him and moved away in the wind.
Sisyphus pushed a stone up a hill, but it always rolled back.
Then Heracles appeared—not the whole man, but his shadow.
He carried a bow, and a belt of gold crossed his chest.
He had entered the darkness while still alive, by the command
of Eurystheus. The dead fled from him as birds flee a hawk.
He recognized me: “Unhappy man, are you too suffering like this?
I endured the living tasks imposed on me, but no man escapes toil.”
He disappeared into the night, and I waited for other heroes.

I saw Theseus and Pirithous, but fear came upon me: perhaps the queen
of the dead would send the Gorgon from below. I returned to the ship,
ordered my companions aboard, and loosened the cables.

The current carried us from Oceanus while the wind grew strong.

Source range: Book 11. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 12

First-pass working translation

When the ship reached Aeaëa, we drew her onto the beach.
We carried Elpenor's body to the shore, cut wood, and burned him
with his armor. We raised a mound beside the sea and set his oar upon it,
as he had asked. Circe came and brought food and wine. All day we ate.
At sunset she said: "You must hear what waits beyond this island.
The Sirens enchant every man who approaches them. They sit in a meadow,
singing, and around them lie the bones of men whose flesh has rotted.
Sail past without hearing their song. Have the crew bind you upright
against the mast; if you beg for release, they must bind you tighter.
Let them stop their ears with wax."
"After the Sirens you will pass two ways. One holds the Wandering Rocks;
no ship escapes them. The other has two cliffs: Scylla lives in one,
Charybdis beneath the other. Charybdis swallows the sea three times
each day and sends it out three times. No ship can survive her whirlpool.
Scylla has six necks and six heads, each with three rows of teeth.
She will seize six men from your ship. Sail close to Scylla's rock;
better to lose six than all your crew."
"Beyond lies Thrinacia, where the cattle of the Sun graze.
Do not touch them. If you leave them unharmed, you may reach Ithaca.
If you harm them, your ship and companions will be destroyed."
We returned to the ship. Circe's wind filled the sail,
and the waves carried us from the island. I told my companions
what the goddess had said, but I did not tell them that Scylla
would take six men, for they would have dropped the oars in fear.
We passed the Sirens. I melted wax and stopped every man's ears.
They bound me to the mast. When we came within the distance of a shout,
the Sirens sang:
"Come here, much-praised Odysseus, glory of the Achaeans.
Stop your ship and hear our voice. No man sails past this meadow
without hearing a sweeter song. We know all the griefs at Troy;
we know all that happens upon the earth."
My heart desired to listen. I motioned for the men to release me,
but Perimedes and Eurylochus bound me tighter. They rowed until
the Sirens' voices faded, then removed the wax and loosened the ropes.

I warned them of the next danger. We saw smoke and breakers,
and heard a great sound. The rowers lost their oars in fear.
I ordered them to row, and told them to keep their eyes on me.
I did not mention Scylla, lest they drop the oars and hide below.
We came near the rock. Charybdis swallowed the sea; it boiled
and roared like a cauldron over a fire. Scylla reached from her cave,
and seized six companions from the ship. I saw their hands and feet
raised toward me, calling my name as if for the last time.
That was the most dreadful sight I endured at sea.
We escaped the strait and reached Thrinacia. My men heard the cattle
lowing. I reminded them of Tiresias and Circe: “Do not touch these herds.
They belong to the Sun, who sees and hears all things.”
Eurylochus answered: “You are hard. You ask men exhausted by hunger
to refuse the cattle. The night is dark; the gods are angry with us.
If we die of hunger, our death is worse than any storm. When we return,
we will build a temple to the Sun. If he destroys our ship, let him.
Better to die at once than perish slowly.”
I wanted to draw my sword, but the men would not listen. They drove
the ship into a bay and swore not to touch the cattle. For a month
the wind blew from the south. We ate the provisions from Circe;
when these ended, the men hunted birds and fish.
At last the wind shifted, and I went inland to pray. Sleep fell upon me.
Eurylochus told the men: “The gods have condemned us. Take the best
of the cattle and sacrifice. When we return to Ithaca, we will build
a great temple for the Sun. If he chooses to sink our ship, we cannot
escape him by starving beside these beasts.”
They drove the finest cattle from the herd. I woke and smelled the smoke.
I came down and saw the skins moving, and the meat lowing on the spits.
I prayed to Zeus, but he gave no sign. The men had broken their oath.
For six days they feasted. On the seventh we launched the ship.
The Sun told the gods: “Punish them, or I will descend to Hades
and shine among the dead.” Zeus promised a thunderbolt.
When we were beyond Thrinacia, a cloud gathered. Zeus struck the ship.
The mast fell upon the steersman and killed him. The ship split;
all the companions fell into the sea. I tied myself to the mast and keel,
and the wind drove them away. I returned to Charybdis and clung
to the fig tree above the whirlpool. The sea swallowed mast and keel,
then cast them out. I dropped upon them and rowed with my hands.

For nine days I drifted. On the tenth night the gods carried me
to Ogygia, where Calypso received me and kept me in her cave.

Source range: Book 12. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 13

First-pass working translation

Odysseus finished his story, and the hall grew silent.
All the Phaeacians sat as if bound by the singer's spell.
Alcinous said: "Now that you have reached my house, you will not remain here. We will send you home, and no one will delay you."
The nobles brought gifts: gold, bronze, and woven garments.
Alcinous told the men to place them in a chest and tie it shut, so that no one might disturb the treasure while Odysseus slept.
The queen gave him a final cloak and urged him to remember the house.
They carried the gifts aboard. Odysseus climbed the ship, and the rowers sat at their benches. Alcinous poured dark wine and prayed to Zeus, Poseidon, and the other gods. The ship left shore as lightly as a four-horse chariot running over a plain.
Odysseus lay in the stern, wrapped in sleep. The Phaeacians rowed through the night. No pilot was needed; their ships knew the route.
At dawn they reached Ithaca, and carried the sleeping hero to the shore, with all his gifts beside him. They placed him beneath an olive tree, near the harbor, and set the treasure in a hidden cave.
Poseidon spoke to Zeus: "The Phaeacians carry men safely over the sea. Now Odysseus has returned. If they continue, all mortals will despise our storms." Zeus replied: "Strike the ship as it comes home, and turn it into stone before the city. Let the people learn restraint."
Poseidon struck. The ship became a stone shape rooted in the sea.
The Phaeacians stood amazed. Alcinous remembered an old prophecy: one day Poseidon would block the harbor with a mountain.
He ordered a sacrifice and commanded that no more stranger-ships leave their land.
Athena came to Ithaca. She found Odysseus waking beneath the tree. The shore looked strange to him, and the gifts lay beside him.
He cried: "What land is this? Have the Phaeacians deceived me? They promised home, but I cannot see my people. Have they stolen my treasure, and carried me somewhere else?"
Athena appeared as a young shepherd. Odysseus asked the way. She answered: "You are in Ithaca. You have reached your homeland."
Odysseus doubted her. He told a false story, saying he had killed

a man in Crete and been put ashore by Phoenicians.
Athena smiled: “You would not cease from cunning, even here.
I am Athena, who stood beside you at Troy and in every danger.
I hid you from the Phaeacians, and now I will hide your treasure.
The suitors consume your house, and Penelope waits in grief.
Telemachus has gone to seek news, and the suitors plot his death.”
She showed him the cave sacred to the nymphs. They placed the gold,
bronze, and clothing within, and sealed the entrance with stone.
Then Athena said: “You must not reveal yourself yet. The suitors
are many, and the household is not ready. Go first to Eumaeus,
the swineherd. He remains faithful, and will tell you the state
of the house. I will go to Sparta and bring Telemachus home.”
Athena changed Odysseus' form. His skin shriveled, his hair fell out,
his clothing became rags, and his eyes looked older. She gave him
a staff and a torn cloak. The king became a beggar to test his house.
“Do not go to the city,” she said. “Wait in the hut. When Telemachus
returns, you will decide how to meet the suitors.”
Athena went toward Lacedaemon. Odysseus climbed over the hills,
crossing the island he had longed for. He reached the hut of Eumaeus,
where four fierce dogs guarded the swine. The dogs rushed at him,
but Eumaeus ran out and scattered them with stones.
He led the stranger inside. “Old man, Zeus has not granted you peace.
Sit here. I have little, but I will not refuse a guest. These pigs
belonged to my master. I grieve for him, though the gods have erased him.
If he returned, he would give me a house, land, and a wife.
But no one has ever come with his news.”
He built a fire, cut a great boar, and divided it into seven portions.
He offered one to the gods, and gave the rest to the stranger and men.
Odysseus ate. Eumaeus poured wine and spoke of the absent king.
Odysseus invented a Cretan tale: he had fought at Troy,
then wandered through Egypt and Phoenicia. He claimed a ship's captain
had left him on Ithaca, and predicted that Odysseus was already home.
Eumaeus answered: “Do not comfort me with lies. I know the truth.
The gods hate my master. He would have returned after Troy,
or died with honor among his friends. His family and servants mourn him.
I have no joy in the suitors' feasts, but I care for these swine.”
Odysseus smiled inwardly. He had found the faithful man.
Night fell over the hut, and the swineherd prepared a bed of skins.

The hidden king slept beneath the roof of his own servant,
while the goddess traveled to fetch his son.

Source range: Book 13. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 14

First-pass working translation

Odysseus climbed to the hills and found Eumaeus' hut.
The swineherd was away, building a pen of stones and thorn,
for his master had left him no wall or shelter for the pigs.
Four dogs rushed at Odysseus. Eumaeus dropped the leather he held,
ran out, and drove them away with stones.
“Old stranger,” he said, “the dogs nearly killed you. That would bring
me shame before the gods. I already have enough grief for Odysseus.
He is gone, and I am left to feed the swine for other men.”
He led Odysseus beneath the shelter and gave him a seat of brush.
He spread a fresh hide, large enough for a chief, and built a fire.
He chose five fat pigs from the herd, singed them, cut them apart,
and offered one portion to the gods. He gave the stranger the best meat.
Odysseus said: “May Zeus reward you. You have welcomed a beggar.”
Eumaeus answered: “Stranger, I cannot insult a guest. All beggars
and strangers come from Zeus. My portion is small, but I give it gladly.
If my master lived, he would give you a house and land.”
He poured wine and spoke of Odysseus:
“The gods have hidden him. I do not know whether the sea or the earth
holds him. His father mourns in the country; his wife remains in the hall;
his son has gone to learn his fate. The suitors consume everything.”
Odysseus invented a Cretan life. He claimed to have fought in Troy,
to have sailed with Idomeneus, and to have won wealth in Egypt.
He told of a Phoenician captain who betrayed him, leaving him
on Ithaca. Then he added: “I heard that Odysseus lives,
and will return with gold. He is near.”
Eumaeus replied: “Old man, you do not comfort me. Many strangers
have come with such stories, and Penelope has wept for each.
Do not swear falsely for food. Odysseus will not return.
I wish he had died before Troy, so the Achaeans could have raised
a mound for him. Then he would have left fame for his house.
Now he has vanished, and my life is a burden.”
Odysseus said: “You are stubborn. I swear that he will come.
Before the suitors take his wife, he will stand in this hut.
I will have no cloak until then, if my word is false.”

Eumaeus laid another hide over him. He told the story of his own life: “I was born on an island ruled by a wealthy man. A Phoenician woman stole me when I was small, and sailors carried me away. They sold me to Laertes, who raised me in Ithaca. I have not forgotten my first home, but I am loyal to the house that fed me.”

The night grew cold. Odysseus asked: “If you had a cloak, would you lend it to a man lying out in the rain?”

Eumaeus answered with a plan. “When the watch begins, I will tell the young men to fetch a cloak from the hut. They will obey, because they fear me.” He gave Odysseus his own cloak for the night.

At dawn he rose and went to the herd. He killed a great boar, prepared the meat, and divided it among the seven portions.

He offered the first to the gods and gave Odysseus his share.

“Eat, stranger. There is no reason to starve. The gods have made our master wait, but they have not taken away the food of a day.”

Odysseus answered: “Tell me, why do you serve this house so faithfully? You are far from your birthplace. Are you the son of a king?”

Eumaeus said: “Why ask my lineage? A man's life is short.

I cannot return to my first land. I care for these swine, and for the absent king. If he came, he would see that I kept faith.”

Odysseus smiled: “Do not mourn. Your master is near. I will tell you when he arrives, though you do not believe me.”

Eumaeus did not answer. He set bread before him, and the two men ate.

The hut stood outside the palace, but within it the true household had begun to recognize itself without knowing the name of its king.

Source range: Book 14. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 15

First-pass working translation

Athena went to Lacedaemon and found Telemachus sleeping in Menelaus' palace. She stood beside him and spoke:

“It is time to return. Your mother has gone to her father, and the suitors have divided your possessions. They fear your return, and have set an ambush in the strait. Go now, before they find you. Ask Nestor's son to take you to Pylos, and send the ship to shore. Then go straight to Eumaeus, who has guarded your herds.”

Telemachus woke and roused Peisistratus. They yoked the horses and drove to Menelaus' house. The king received them at dawn.

Telemachus said: “I must leave. My house waits, and I fear the suitors.”

Menelaus answered: “I will not detain you. Take these gifts: a mixing bowl and a cup, and a robe for the day you marry. Go with the gods' protection.” Helen gave him a garment and spoke a sign: “Like an eagle returning to its nest, your father will return to his house and punish those who consume it.”

They drove to Pylos. At the shore Telemachus asked Peisistratus to let him leave before reaching Nestor's palace. “I am ashamed to be detained by an old friend when danger waits at home.”

Peisistratus agreed, and they reached the ship at night.

Telemachus found Theoclymenus, a seer descended from Melampus, fleeing a blood-price. He clasped Telemachus' knees:

“Take me aboard. If you refuse, I will be killed.”

Telemachus answered: “Come. We will share what the gods provide.”

They sailed from Pylos while the darkness covered the shore.

Theoclymenus saw a hawk carrying a dove in its claws; feathers fell into the sea. He said: “Your house will rule Ithaca. No man among the suitors will overcome you.”

Meanwhile Eumaeus sat with the disguised Odysseus. He told him:

“My master is gone, but the gods have not forgotten him. Telemachus has gone to seek news. I fear the suitors' ambush.”

Odysseus answered: “Tell me your life again. Were you born here?”

Eumaeus described the island of Syria, his wealthy father's house, and the Phoenician woman who carried him away as a child. She sold him to Laertes, who raised him. Odysseus listened,

and for a moment nearly revealed himself, but the time was not ready.
At dawn Eumaeus and Odysseus saw a stranger approaching.
It was Theoclymenus, who had come ashore after the ship arrived.
Eumaeus welcomed him and gave him food. The seer asked:
“Who is the master of this house? Is he here?”
Eumaeus replied: “Odysseus has been gone many years.
His son has traveled, and the suitors consume his wealth.
You have come to a sorrowful place.”
Theoclymenus said: “The son is near. I saw the sign in the sky.
He will return, and the suitors will not keep the house.”
Telemachus steered toward Ithaca. He told his companions:
“Hide the ship. I do not want the suitors to see me return.
Send the gifts to the house by night.”
He and Theoclymenus went toward Eumaeus' hut. The swineherd
was preparing breakfast. He saw his young master and wept,
embracing him as a father embraces a son returned from a distant war.
Telemachus entered the hut and greeted Eumaeus. The swineherd
asked whether the ship had brought good news. Telemachus said:
“The gods kept me alive. But tell me what the suitors are doing.”
Odysseus watched his son. The time to reveal the truth was close,
but the hut still held one more test of courage and recognition.

Source range: Book 15. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 16

First-pass working translation

At dawn Telemachus came to Eumaeus' hut. The dogs did not bark;
they recognized their master. Eumaeus embraced him and kissed his face,
as a father welcomes a son returned from a long journey.

Telemachus asked: "What news of the house? Do the suitors still feast?
Have they learned that I have returned?"

Eumaeus answered: "They know nothing. But tell me what you learned.
Did Menelaus have any news of your father?"

Telemachus said: "He gave me gifts, but no certainty. He heard that
Odysseus was alive, held by Calypso. The suitors have set an ambush.
Take the gifts to the city, and tell my mother I have returned safely.

Do not tell her that I am here. I will go to the palace later."

Eumaeus went to Penelope. Athena then appeared to Odysseus,
and told him to reveal himself to his son:

"The hour has come. Tell him everything, and plan the death of the suitors.
Then return to the city together."

Athena touched him. His rags fell away; his body became young and strong.
His hair curled, his cloak shone, and he looked like a god.

Telemachus saw the stranger and thought him a god. He stepped back:

"Surely you are not a mortal. If you are a god, tell me what you desire.

We will sacrifice to you."

Odysseus answered: "I am no god. I am your father, whom you have sought.
I have suffered long, and have returned under another man's clothes."

Telemachus stared. He thought the man might be deceiving him.

Odysseus sat and wept. Telemachus wept also, and they clung together,
like an eagle's young when their parents return with food.

Telemachus asked: "How did you come? Who brought you? You could not
have crossed the sea alone."

Odysseus told him the Phaeacians carried him sleeping to Ithaca,
and Athena guarded him. He showed the cave where the gifts lay.

"Now tell me the suitors' number. Can two men face them,
or must we call allies from the island?"

Telemachus answered: "There are many: the best men of Ithaca and the islands.
We need help."

Odysseus said: "Athena and Zeus will stand with us. First return to the house.

When the suitors see me, they will think I am a beggar. If they strike me, do not defend me openly. Carry the weapons from the hall to the upper room, leaving only two swords, two spears, and shields for us.”

“If someone asks why, say the smoke has damaged them, or that they no longer belong to the men who fight. The suitors must not know our plan.”

Telemachus went to the city. The dogs barked at the house, but he entered.

Penelope ran to him and embraced him, asking what he had learned.

He told her only that Menelaus had received him well, and that no news was certain. She wept, and said: “The suitors will kill you when they can.”

Theoclymenus arrived and told them: “Your son is like a hawk beneath the roof. The suitors are in darkness; they have no escape.”

Penelope welcomed the seer, while Telemachus and the heralds carried the weapons from the hall. When the suitors saw them, they laughed.

One said: “Telemachus has come back wiser than before. He will not keep his anger long.”

Amphinomus asked whether the ambush had failed. Telemachus concealed the truth, saying he had escaped the sea's dangers by the gods' favor.

Eumaeus returned to the hut. Odysseus had taken his old form again.

Telemachus asked him: “What does the town say? Have they heard of my return?”

Eumaeus answered: “The message has gone to Penelope. The gifts are safe.”

Odysseus and his son planned through the night. Athena stood beside them, and the moon shone over the hut. The two men had found one another, but the house still waited for the name and the spear.

Source range: Book 16. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 17

First-pass working translation

Telemachus and Theoclymenus reached the city. Telemachus sent the seer to the house of Eurymachus, where he would be received as a guest. He went to the palace, and his mother ran toward him. She asked about his journey, and he told her Menelaus' report: Odysseus lived, but no one knew when he would return.

Penelope wept. The old nurse Eurycleia embraced Telemachus, and the women gathered around him. The suitors came with gifts, pretending friendship, while Antinous spoke in a smooth voice:

“You have returned. We feared you were lost. Let us hold a feast. Your mother should choose the best of us and end this delay.”

Telemachus answered: “You cannot force her. She will decide as she wishes. I will not send her from the house. Feast if you desire, but do not ask me to provide the cattle and wine you have consumed.”

Theoclymenus warned him: “I saw a sign. A shadow covered the walls; the suitors' blood will fill the house.” The suitors laughed at the seer.

Odysseus and Eumaeus left the hut. Eumaeus walked ahead; the disguised king followed with his staff. Athena had changed him into the old beggar again. They reached the road to the palace.

A goatherd named Melanthius met them. He insulted Odysseus:

“Where do you lead this glutton? Let him beg at another door.

If he came to my table, I would break his ribs.” He kicked Odysseus, but the king did not move. He thought of striking him dead, then chose to wait.

Eumaeus rebuked the goatherd: “May the gods punish you.

You have forgotten your master, who fed you when you were young.”

The palace dog Argos lay upon a heap of dung, old and full of ticks.

He had once been swift, bred for the hunt, but Odysseus left before the dog reached manhood. No one cared for him now.

Argos raised his head and recognized Odysseus. His ears moved; he struggled to come near, but he could not. Odysseus turned away, so Eumaeus would not see his tears. The dog died when he had seen his master again, after twenty years.

Eumaeus entered the hall and ate with Telemachus. Odysseus remained at the doors, begging from the suitors. They gave little. Antinous

threw a stool and struck his shoulder.
Odysseus stood firm and said: "You struck a beggar for no reason.
May the gods return this blow upon you before your wedding day."
Antinous laughed. "Leave the hall, or my stool will not be the last."
The suitors watched, uneasy, while Telemachus sat silent, holding his grief.
Penelope heard that the stranger had been beaten. She told Eumaeus:
"Bring him to me. I will ask whether he knows anything of Odysseus.
Perhaps he has traveled and heard his name."
Odysseus answered: "Let night fall. I will speak when the suitors leave.
I fear the men who rule this hall." Eumaeus carried the message.
Penelope sat among the women, weaving and thinking. She said:
"Never has such a stranger come to my house. He walks like a king,
though his clothes are torn. Perhaps he knows my husband."
The suitors continued their feast. Ctesippus, a man without measure,
threw an ox's foot at Odysseus, saying: "Take this guest-gift."
Odysseus moved aside, and the foot struck the wall. Telemachus rose:
"Ctesippus, you are fortunate that your weapon missed. If it had struck,
I would have killed you here. You are not feasting in your own house."
The suitors laughed, but some understood the threat. Amphinomus gave
Odysseus bread and wine. The disguised king said inwardly:
"May you escape the day that approaches, if your heart is innocent."
Telemachus told Eumaeus to return to the hut at dawn. "My mother
will ask for the stranger tonight. Do not tell her that he is my father.
We must keep the plan hidden."
The suitors went home. Odysseus remained beneath the roof,
looking at the men who had consumed his house. Athena stood near him,
and the night moved toward recognition.

Source range: Book 17. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 18

First-pass working translation

Irus, a beggar who ruled the doorway, came when Odysseus entered.
He ordered him out: "This is my place. Leave, or I will strike you."
Odysseus answered: "There is room for both of us. Do not make trouble.
You are young, but the gods may turn your fortune."
Irus challenged him. Antinous rejoiced and promised a portion of meat
to the winner. Odysseus pulled up his rags and revealed his thighs,
shoulders, and powerful arms. The suitors stepped back in fear.
Irus struck first, but Odysseus hit him beneath the ear.
His jaw broke; blood poured from his mouth, and he fell in the dust.
The suitors laughed. Antinous gave Odysseus a great stomach of meat,
while Amphinomus offered bread and wished him well.
Odysseus said inwardly: "May you escape the day when this house falls."
Penelope appeared among the suitors, made beautiful by Athena.
She told the women to bring her veil, and went down the hall.
She reminded the suitors that Odysseus had left her a command:
"Do not marry until my son has grown a beard."
She said: "You consume my house, and offer no proper gifts.
Let each of you bring gold, garments, and ornaments. A bride's honor
should not be taken from another man's house without payment."
The suitors competed to please her. Antinous gave a beautiful necklace;
Eurymachus brought a gold chain and shining earrings. The attendants
carried the gifts to the upper room.
Odysseus watched her and thought: "She has turned their greed into gifts."
The suitors feasted. Athena made them laugh until they lost their minds.
Ctesippus threw an ox's foot at Odysseus. He moved aside, and the foot
struck the wall. Telemachus rose:
"Ctesippus, you were fortunate. If you had struck the stranger,
I would have killed you. You have no restraint in this house."
The suitors stared. Agelaus urged peace: "Telemachus speaks rightly.
Let no one insult the guest. The omen is bad. Your mother should marry,
and you should take care of your property."
Telemachus answered: "I do not forbid her. Let her choose as she wishes.
But I will not allow anyone to drive her away."
The feast ended. Medon told Penelope the suitors' laughter had become

violent. She returned to her chamber and wept for Odysseus.
Odysseus lay beneath the roof, thinking of the men who had struck him.
Athena came and said: “You have endured long enough. Tomorrow the bow
will enter your hands, and the suitors will learn your name.”
He answered: “Let them remain unaware. My heart is ready.”
The hall slept. Odysseus remained awake, and Penelope's grief moved
through the house like a cold wind. The weapons had been hidden;
the bow waited for the day when disguise would end.

Source range: Book 18. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 19

First-pass working translation

Odysseus and Telemachus moved the weapons from the hall.
Athena held a golden lamp, and the room shone with an unnatural light.
Telemachus said: “Surely a god is helping us.”
Odysseus answered: “Be silent. The gods have made this possible.”
When the suitors had left, Penelope came down. She sat apart,
like Artemis or Aphrodite, and spoke to the stranger:
“You have entered my house, but you have not told me who you are.
Tell me your lineage, your city, and the people who raised you.”
Odysseus invented another Cretan tale. He said he was born
to a wealthy king, and that he had met Odysseus in Crete.
He described Odysseus' purple cloak, golden brooch, and double fold;
he said the king wore a dark wool shirt close upon his skin.
Penelope wept, because she recognized the clothing's likeness.
Odysseus said: “Do not weep. I heard that he is alive,
and that he gathered treasure in Thesprotis. He will soon return.”
Penelope answered: “Dreams are difficult to understand. Twenty geese
come from the water and eat my grain; an eagle kills them all.
I grieve, but the eagle says: these geese are the suitors,
and my husband will return to kill them.”
Odysseus replied: “The dream has spoken clearly. The man will return.
The suitors' death is close.”
Penelope said: “My life is divided. Odysseus has been gone twenty years.
I cannot remain unmarried forever, but I cannot willingly abandon his house.
Tomorrow I will set out his bow and axes. I will marry the man
who can bend the bow and shoot through the twelve axes.”
Odysseus answered: “Do not delay. Before these suitors compete,
Odysseus will return, and none will escape.”
Penelope ordered the old nurse Eurycleia to wash the stranger.
She washed his feet, and recognized the scar above his knee,
made by a boar's tusk when he hunted with his grandfather Autolycus.
Eurycleia touched it and cried: “You are Odysseus! How did I not know?”
She turned toward Penelope, but Odysseus seized her throat and whispered:
“Do not tell her. If the gods have helped me, I will kill the suitors first.”
The nurse promised silence. Athena distracted Penelope, so she heard nothing.

Penelope returned and said: “Stranger, tell me the truth of Odysseus.
What clothes wore he? What was his appearance? What companions followed?”
Odysseus described the man exactly. He told of the cloak and brooch,
of the herald Eurybates, and of Odysseus' shoulders and eyes.
Penelope listened, but did not recognize him. The gods had set a veil
between her and the truth until the proper hour.
She sent the nurse to prepare the stranger's bed. Odysseus lay down
beneath the roof, thinking of the bow and the coming judgment.

Source range: Book 19. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 20

First-pass working translation

Odysseus lay upon the hide beneath the portico, awake and thinking.
He wondered whether he could face the suitors alone. Athena came near:
“Why wake? Your wife is in the house, your son beside you,
and you are ready to punish those who have consumed your wealth.”
Odysseus answered: “I know you are with me, but I fear their number.
If we were more, I would be less afraid. We must find a way to survive.”
Athena said: “The gods are stronger than men. Sleep now.”
She poured sleep over his eyes, and he rested briefly.
Penelope awoke and wept. She prayed: “Artemis, take my life.
Let me die now, so I may join Odysseus, rather than be given
to a man I do not love.” The goddess heard her grief.
The suitors entered the hall and resumed their feast. Telemachus
stood among them without fear. Ctesippus mocked him, but no one answered.
The suitors discussed Penelope, each claiming the right to marry her.
Theoclymenus saw a darkness over the hall. He cried:
“What evil is this? The walls are wet with blood. The air is full
of faces like the dead. The sun has vanished, and night covers the room.”
Eurymachus laughed: “The stranger has lost his mind.”
Theoclymenus answered: “You will not laugh for long.” He left the house.
Telemachus told Eumaeus and the other servants to prepare the hall.
Eumaeus mourned the absent king, while Odysseus watched his faith.
A maid laughed at Odysseus and insulted him. He warned her:
“Do not rejoice in another man's sorrow. The day of judgment is near.”
The suitors drank. Athena stirred their minds, and they laughed wildly.
Agelaus urged them to stop: “Telemachus has grown strong. Let him marry,
and let the rest of us return to our homes.”
Telemachus answered: “My mother will decide. I will not send her away.
But no one will force me to pay for this feast.”
Amphinomus saw a sign outside: a thunderclap from a clear sky.
Odysseus smiled. The suitors did not understand.
When darkness came, the servants set the hall in order. Odysseus
and Telemachus checked the doors and the weapons. Athena stood nearby,
and the house waited for the bow.

Source range: Book 20. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 21

First-pass working translation

Penelope brought out the great bow of Odysseus and the axes.

She placed the weapons before the suitors and said:

“Here is the bow he carried. The man who bends it and sends an arrow through the twelve axes shall become my husband. I will leave this house, though it is full of wealth and memories.”

Telemachus set the axes in a row and made the channel straight.

He tried the bow first. Three times he bent it almost to the string, but Odysseus gave him a sign. On the fourth attempt he would have strung it, but his father shook his head. Telemachus sat down.

The suitors began. They softened the bow with grease and held it to the fire.

Leodes tried, but could not bend it. Antinous said the bow was too hard, and ordered the goatherd to heat it. The suitors took turns, but none could.

Odysseus went outside and revealed himself to Eumaeus and Philoetius.

He asked whether they would stand with their king. Eumaeus wept;

Philoetius swore to defend him. Odysseus told them to shut the doors, and to bring weapons when he gave the sign.

Penelope returned and said: “Let the stranger try. Odysseus may have given him the bow himself. The man who can bend it should receive me.”

Telemachus answered: “No man has more right to decide than I.

But go to your room. The contest belongs to men.”

She smiled and went upstairs, while Athena made her sleep.

Antinous ordered the bow brought to him. He tried and failed.

Eurymachus tried and failed, embarrassed before the others.

Odysseus asked for the bow. Antinous rejected him:

“Do not make us laugh. You have drunk too much wine.”

Penelope said: “Give it to the stranger. A guest deserves a trial.”

Telemachus urged the servants to obey. Eumaeus carried the bow out, but the suitors shouted. Penelope heard, and Telemachus ordered her away.

Eumaeus placed the bow in Odysseus' hands. He turned the weapon, examined every joint, and strung it as easily as a singer stretches a new string upon a lyre. The bow sang. The suitors fell silent.

Odysseus took an arrow from the quiver and set it on the cord.

He drew, and sent it through all twelve axes without touching the line.

The arrow passed cleanly. Zeus thundered.

Odysseus said: “The contest is done. Now there is another mark.”
He cast away his rags and stood in the doorway with the bow.
Telemachus armed himself. Eumaeus shut the outer door;
Philoetius locked the gate and tied the rope.
Antinous was lifting a cup of wine. Odysseus shot him in the throat.
The cup fell; blood covered the table. The suitors rose in confusion,
thinking the shot accidental. Odysseus spoke:
“You thought I would never return. You consumed my house,
pressed my wife, and killed the cattle without fear of the gods.
Now the hour of your death has come.”
The suitors searched for weapons, but Telemachus had carried them away.
Athena stood behind Odysseus in the likeness of Mentor,
and the hall became the place where the hidden king would be revealed.

Source range: Book 21. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 22

First-pass working translation

Odysseus shot Antinous through the throat. The cup fell, and the suitors rose in confusion. Eurymachus cried: “If you are Odysseus, your anger is just. Antinous planned the ambush, but we were only following him. Take gold from each house and we will repay what we consumed.”

Odysseus answered: “You would offer me all your fathers' wealth, and I would still kill you. There is no escape.”

Eurymachus attacked. Odysseus shot him in the chest. Amphinomus rushed him, but Telemachus pierced him from behind. The hall filled with shouting. Telemachus brought armor for himself, Eumaeus, and Philoetius. He returned for more, but Melanthius climbed to the storeroom and brought weapons to the suitors. Eumaeus and Philoetius caught him, bound him, and left him hanging among the rafters.

Athena appeared above the hall as Mentor. Odysseus asked her aid, but she remained at first to test their strength. Agelaus called the suitors: “Shoot the bowman. If we kill Odysseus, the others cannot stand.”

They threw spears at him. Athena turned them aside. Odysseus, Telemachus, Eumaeus, and Philoetius cast back. The suitors fell.

Leiodes clasped Odysseus' knees: “I never harmed the house. I tried to restrain the others.” Odysseus replied: “You poured wine for them. You shared their feast. No one among you is innocent.” He killed him.

Phemius, the singer, and Medon, the herald, begged for mercy.

Telemachus spoke: “They did not choose their service. Spare them.”

Odysseus accepted the plea, and they hid beside the altar.

Ctesippus threw a spear, but Philoetius struck him first: “Take this guest-gift, the ox's foot you cast at our master.”

Agelaus shouted for the doors to be opened, but they were locked.

Melanthius had been stripped of armor; he had brought weapons up, but could bring no more down. The suitors' hands were empty.

Athena took Mentor's shape and stood with Odysseus. The suitors trembled.

Odysseus called: “Now I will fight until the last man falls.”

The arrow and spear moved through the hall. Amphimedon struck Telemachus, but the wound was light. Telemachus killed Amphimedon. Eumaeus killed the goat-herd. Philoetius held the gate. Athena raised the aegis, and the suitors saw the Gorgon face. They fled from one end of the room

to another, like cattle driven by a gadfly.

Agelaus urged escape through the windows, but Odysseus shot him.

The suitors' weapons ran out. The hall was filled with bodies and blood.

Odysseus looked around for any living enemy. There were none.

Telemachus asked what to do with the disloyal women and Melanthius.

Odysseus answered: "First cleanse the hall with fire and sulfur.

Then punish those who betrayed the house."

They brought the women who had slept with the suitors and made them carry the dead outside. They washed the tables and benches.

Melanthius was brought down and mutilated. The hall was cleansed.

Odysseus told Eurycleia to call the faithful women. The old nurse recognized him and would have shouted, but he stopped her:

"Rejoice in silence. It is not holy to triumph over the dead."

She named the servants who had remained loyal. They came and embraced their king, kissing his hands and shoulders. The house had been taken back, but recognition between Odysseus and Penelope still remained.

Source range: Book 22. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 23

First-pass working translation

Eurycleia ran to Penelope and called: “Wake, dear child. Odysseus is here. He has killed the suitors. The stranger was your husband.”

Penelope answered: “The gods have driven you mad. Odysseus is dead. That man may resemble him, but no one can return after twenty years.”

She came down. Odysseus sat among the bodies, his clothes stained.

He said: “Your wife doubts me. Perhaps the gods have changed her mind. Give me a bath and a bed.”

Telemachus cried: “Mother, you have a hard heart. No other man could have done these things. He is here, and the house is ours again.”

Penelope answered: “I am not proud or foolish. If he is Odysseus, we will know each other by signs no one else possesses.”

She told the nurse: “Make up a bed outside the bedchamber.

Move the bedstead; Odysseus can sleep there.”

Odysseus heard and said: “Who moved my bed? It was built around an olive tree. I cut the trunk, raised walls around it, and fitted the bedposts. No man could move it without cutting the tree.”

Penelope's knees failed. She ran to him and embraced him.

She wept into his hair, while he wept for the wife and the house he had nearly lost. Athena held back the dawn so the night would last.

Odysseus told her of his wanderings, and of Tiresias' command:

he must travel inland with an oar, sacrifice to Poseidon, and return before death came to him from the sea. He told her the Phaeacians had carried him home and that Athena had guided the slaughter.

The nurse prepared the bed. Odysseus and Penelope spoke through the night, each asking about the years that had passed. At dawn, Odysseus said:

“I must visit my father. The families of the suitors will hear of their death and may come with weapons. We must leave the city until Athena and Zeus decide the end.”

He armed Telemachus, Eumaeus, and Philoetius. They left the palace through the orchard, carrying spears. Penelope and the women remained, while Phemius spread the song of a wedding through the house, so the townspeople would think a marriage feast was taking place.

The roads opened toward Laertes' farm. Odysseus walked in silence, approaching the old man who had withdrawn from the city in grief.

Source range: Book 23. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 24

First-pass working translation

Hermes led the souls of the suitors to the land of the dead.
They passed Oceanus and the gates where the dead gather.
Agamemnon's shade saw them and asked why so many young men had fallen.
Amphimedon told the story: Penelope's delay, the bow, the stranger,
and the slaughter. Agamemnon praised Penelope's faithfulness:
“Her fame will live, unlike Clytemnestra's. She did not kill her husband.”
In Ithaca, Odysseus and his companions reached Laertes' farm.
The old man worked in the orchard, wearing a dirty tunic.
Odysseus entered and tested him, asking for the man who had owned
the orchard. Laertes described Odysseus' childhood trees.
Odysseus could no longer hide. He embraced his father and said:
“I am your son. I have returned after twenty years, and I have killed
the men who consumed our house.”
Laertes doubted him until Odysseus showed the scar and named
the trees he had received as a child. Laertes' strength returned;
he stood like a god. The old man was washed and dressed by the servants.
Dolius and his sons came from the fields. They heard that Odysseus
had returned, and took up weapons. The household gathered around him.
News of the suitors' death reached their families. They carried armor
through the streets and demanded blood-price. Eupeithes, Antinous' father,
called for revenge. Medon and the herald told the elders that Odysseus
had acted with divine support.
The people split. Some wanted war; others remembered the years of feasting
and theft. The suitors' families marched toward Laertes' farm.
Athena asked Zeus: “Will this quarrel continue, or shall Ithaca have peace?”
Zeus answered: “Let Odysseus rule, but make the people forget the bloodshed.
Let the families swear friendship, and let peace settle over the island.”
Odysseus armed himself. Telemachus, Eumaeus, Philoetius, Laertes,
and Dolius stood beside him. Laertes prayed to Athena and struck Eupeithes.
Odysseus would have pursued the others, but Zeus thundered.
Athena cried: “Stop. The war has ended.” The people lowered their weapons.
They swore peace with the house of Odysseus. The smoke rose from the farm,
and Ithaca returned to its king.

Source range: Book 24. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.